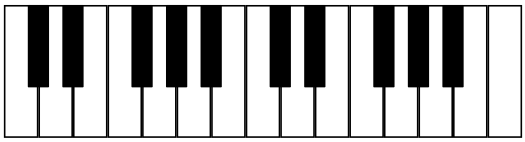
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Technique: Scales, Arpeggios and Chords



Middle C

Ten minutes a day alongside the volumes:
six stages, one for each volume, with standard fingering throughout.

How to use this book

Why technique

Sight-reading trains your eyes; technique trains your hands to do what your eyes see. Scales, arpeggios and chords are the shapes most music is built from: once your hands know them, you recognise them on the page and play them without working them out.

How long

About ten minutes a day, at the start of practice, before sight-reading. Work on the stage that goes with the volume you are reading; keep the earlier stages going, a few keys a day.

How to practise

1. Hands separately until the fingering is automatic, then hands together. 2. Slowly, with the metronome, every note even in time and in loudness. 3. Use exactly the fingering printed: it is the standard one, chosen so the thumb lands on a white key and the hand never runs out of fingers. 4. Raise the speed by 4-8 beats per minute only after two clean runs. 5. Stay relaxed: shoulders down, wrist level, no tension in the thumb as it passes under. Stop and shake out the hand if anything tightens.

Target speeds

Speeds to aim for by the end of each stage (sixteenths: four notes to each beat; arpeggios in triplets at two-thirds of that): Stage 1: ♩ = 60, eighths; Stage 2: ♩ = 60-72, eighths; Stage 3: ♩ = 60, sixteenths; Stage 4: ♩ = 72, sixteenths; Stage 5: ♩ = 80, sixteenths; Stage 6: ♩ = 96 and up.

Pieces above your reading level

Keep learning pieces you love that are harder than you can sight-read: that is how most pianists work. Reading (the volumes) trains the eyes on lots of easy music played once; pieces (Volume 7, or any you choose) train the hands, memory and musicianship over weeks. A good rule: choose pieces about two levels above your sight-reading. Much higher, and you spend months decoding notes instead of making music. Learn them as Volume 7 describes: hard places first, in short sections, slowly.

The stages

Stage 1 With Volume 1: Five-finger patterns

Stage 2 With Volume 2: One-octave scales and broken chords

Stage 3 With Volume 3: Two-octave scales, arpeggios and inversions

Stage 4 With Volume 4: New keys, cadences, chromatic scale

Stage 5 With Volume 5: Every key

Stage 6 With Volumes 6 and 7: Contrary motion and inverted arpeggios

Fingering: 1 is the thumb, 5 the little finger, in both hands. Right-hand fingers are printed above the notes, left-hand fingers below. Scale fingerings follow the standard chart (the fourth finger falls once in each octave on a fixed note of the key); arpeggio fingerings follow the chart of Prof. Escandon (University of Miami), as published by B. Burt.

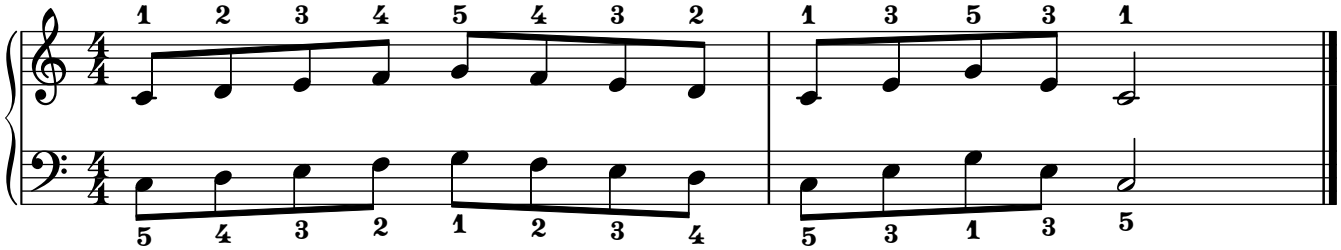
Stage 1 - With Volume 1

Five-finger patterns

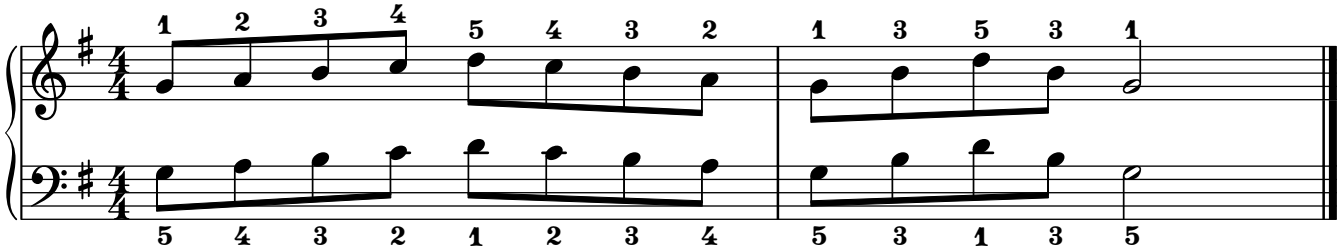
Each pattern: up and down the five notes, then the broken chord (1-3-5-3-1). Hands separately first, then together. Keep every finger curved over its own key and play from the fingertip.

Five-finger patterns

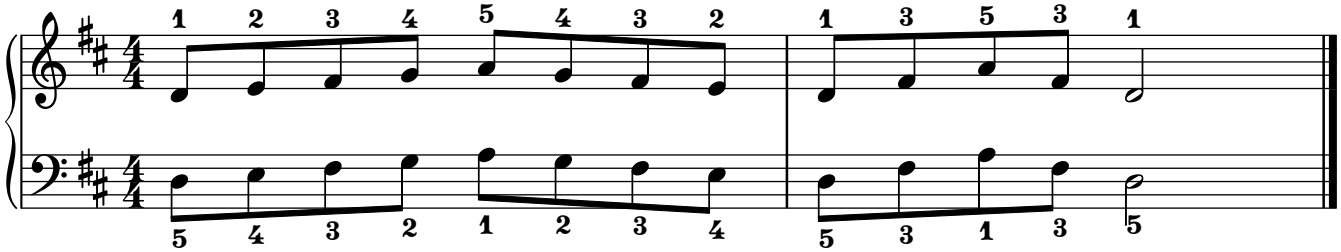
☐ **C major**



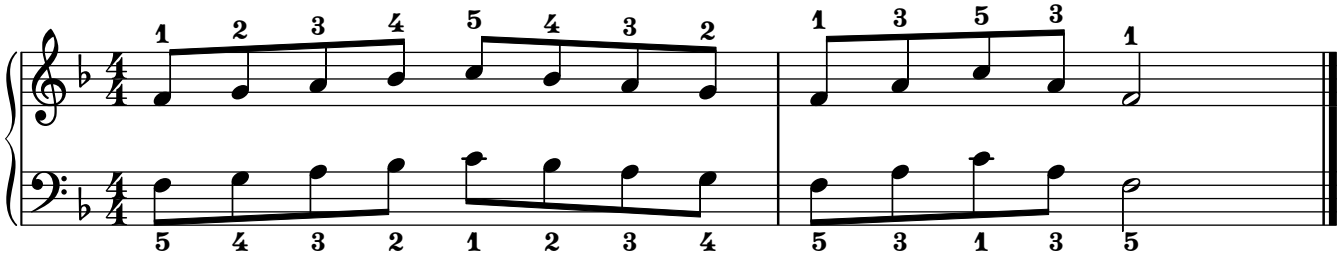
☐ **G major**



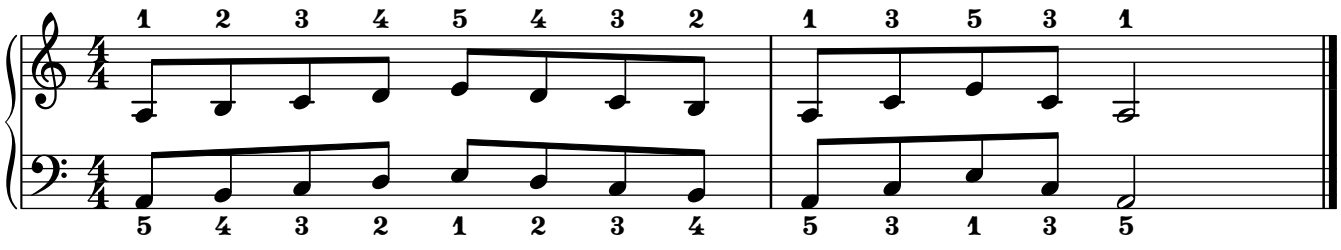
☐ **D major**



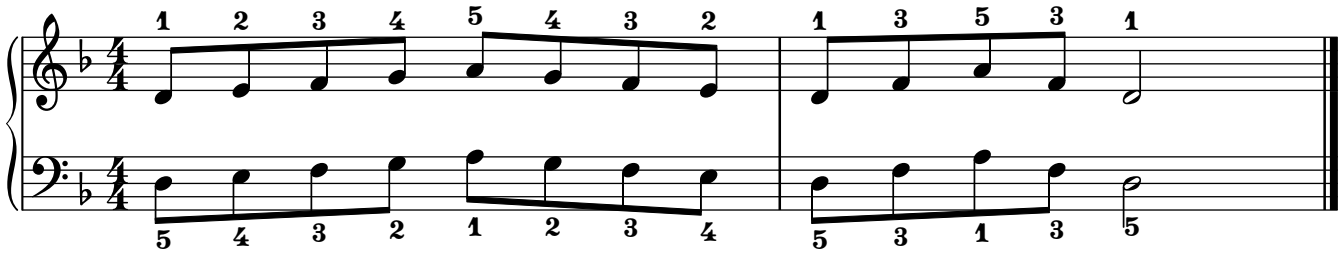
☐ **F major**



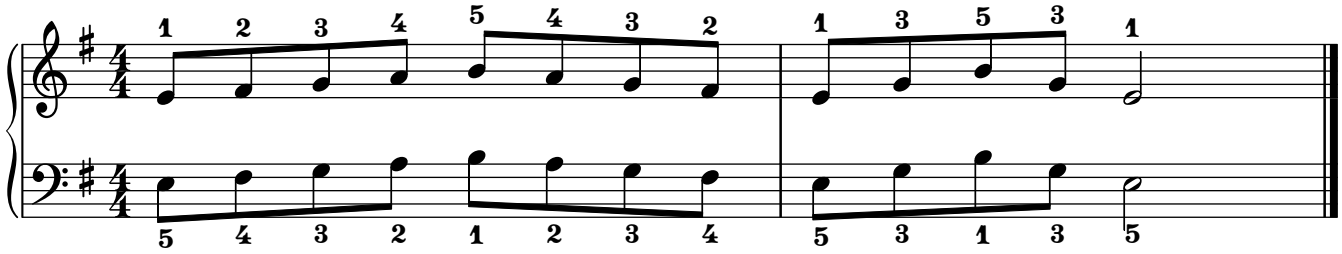
☐ **A minor**



☐ **D minor**



☐ **E minor**



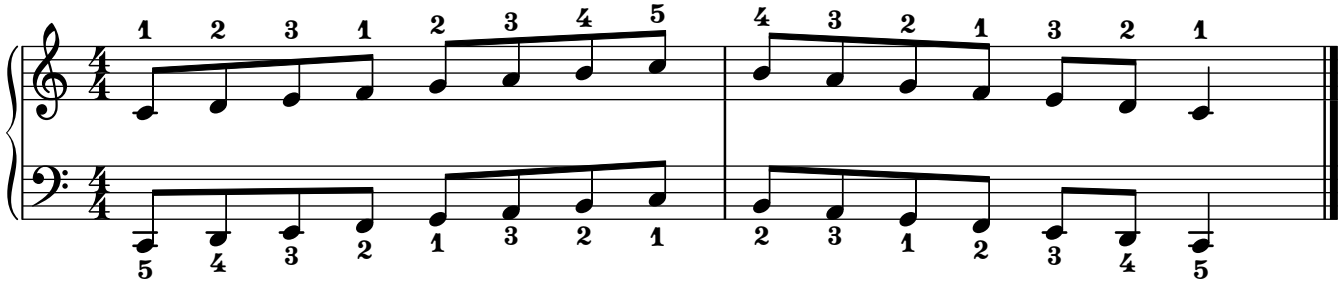
Stage 2 - With Volume 2

One-octave scales and broken chords

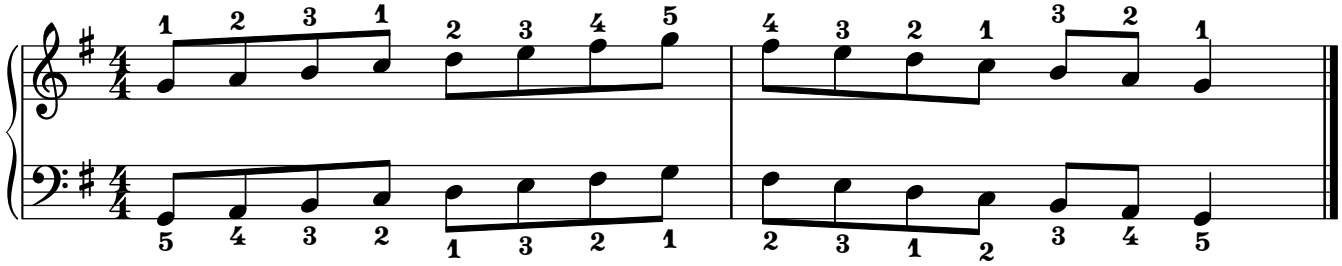
The thumb now passes under the hand (right hand going up, left hand going down) and the third or fourth finger crosses over it. Pass the thumb early and smoothly, without a bump; the wrist stays level and quiet.

One-octave scales

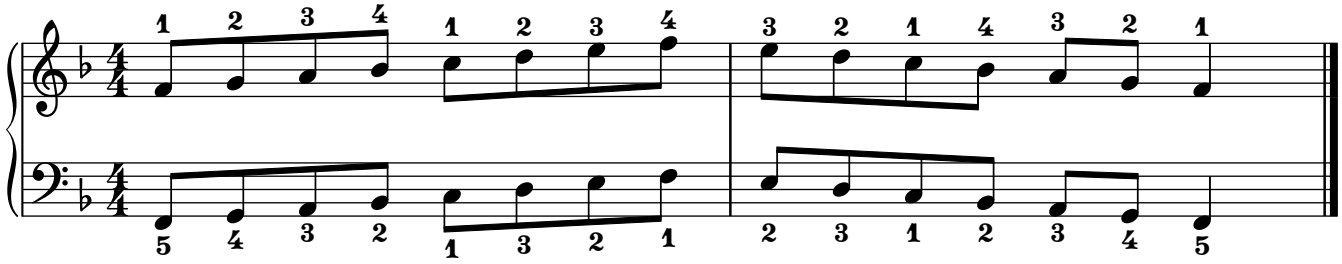
☐ **C major**



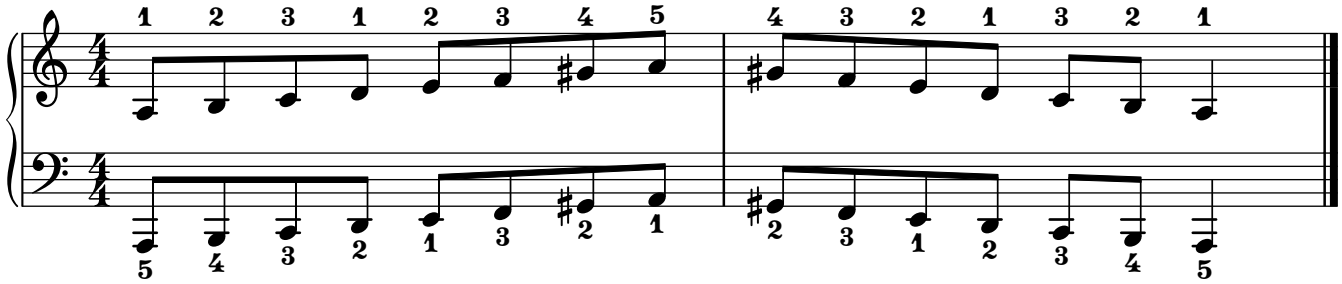
☐ **G major**



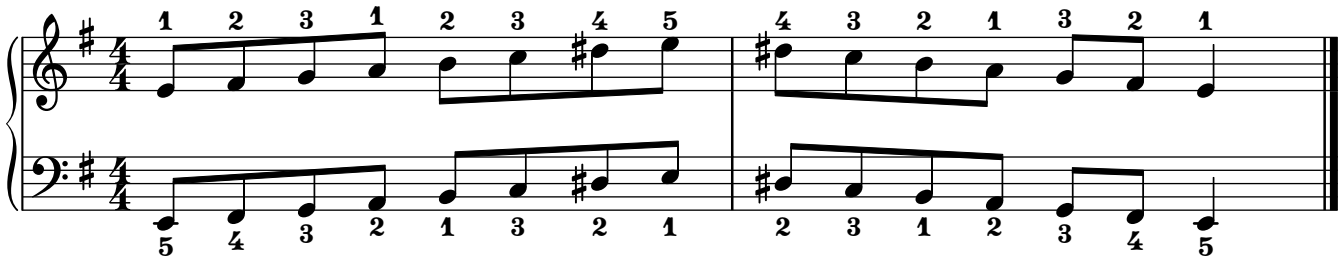
☐ **F major**



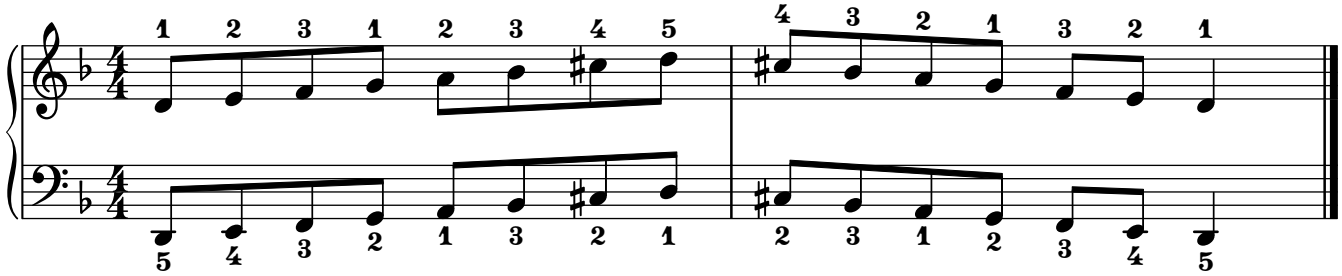
☐ **A minor (harmonic)**



☐ **E minor (harmonic)**

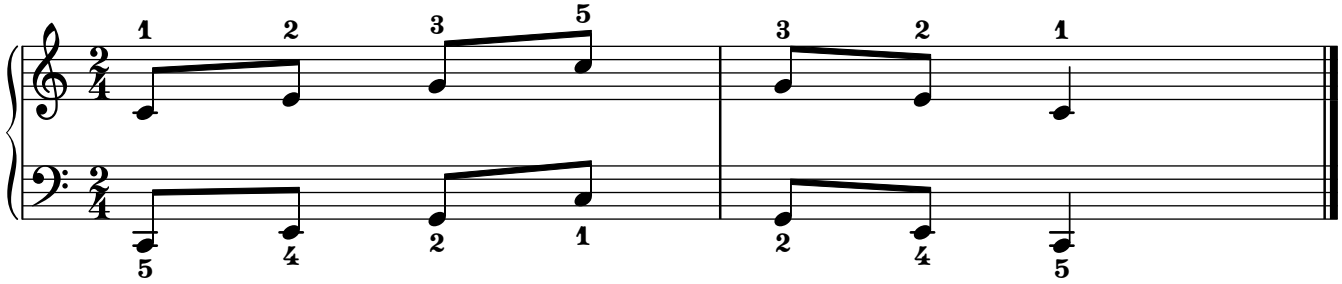


☐ **D minor (harmonic)**

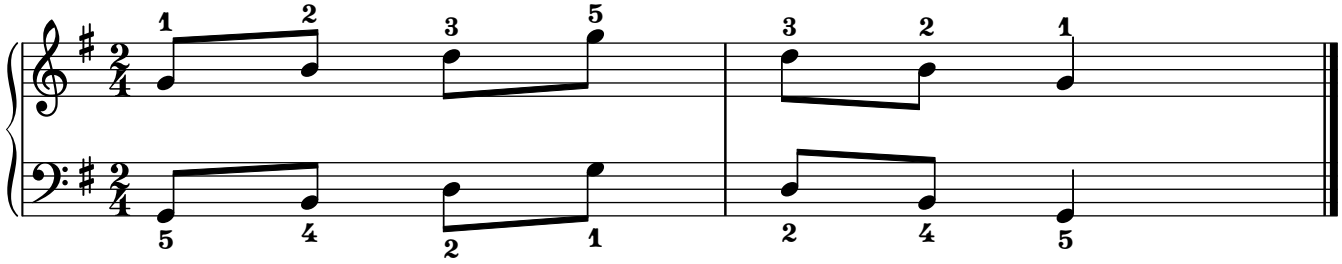


Broken chords

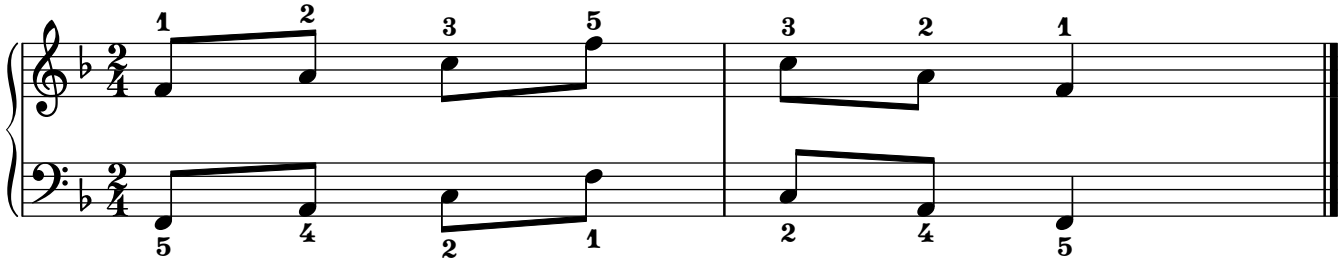
☐ **C major**



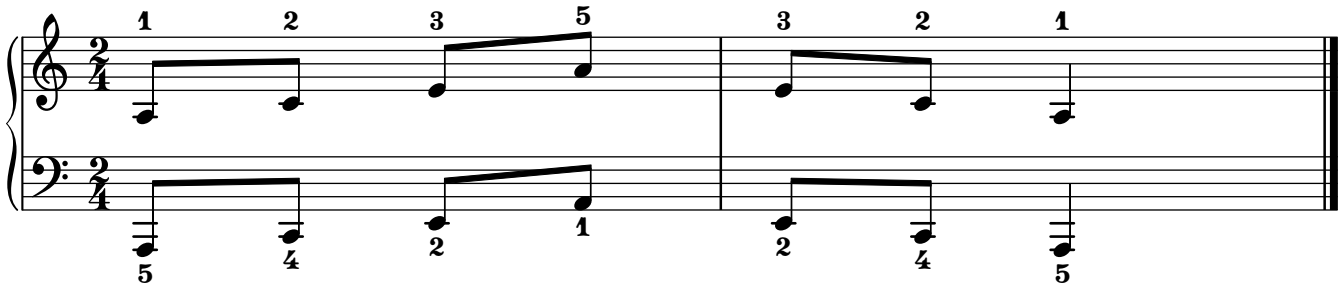
☐ **G major**



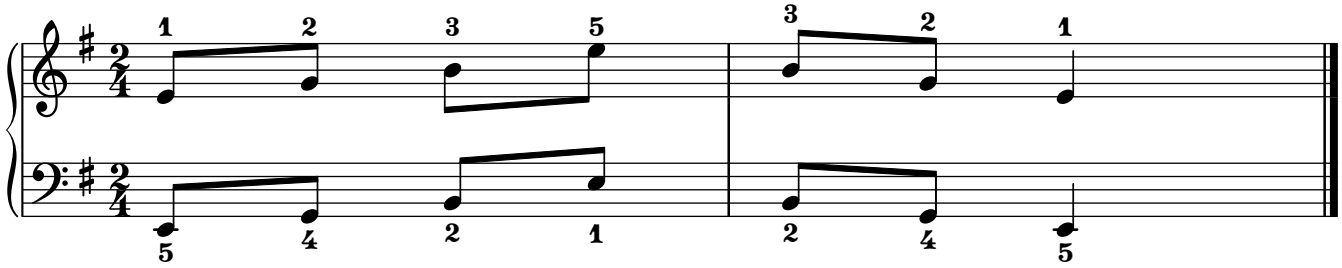
☐ **F major**



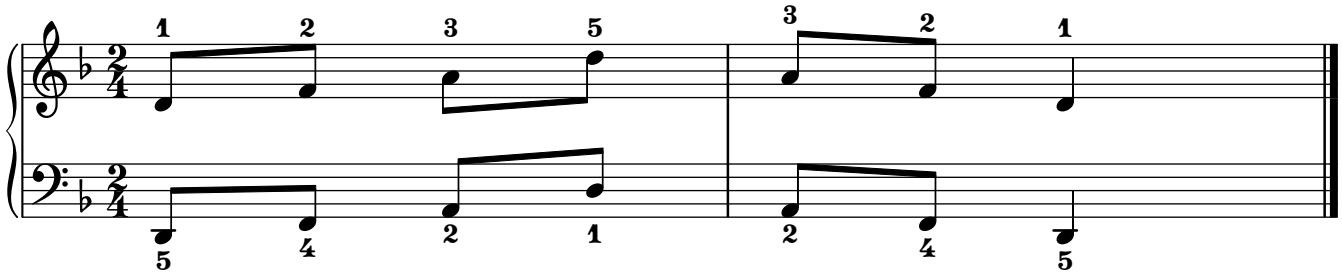
☐ **A minor**



☐ **E minor**



☐ **D minor**



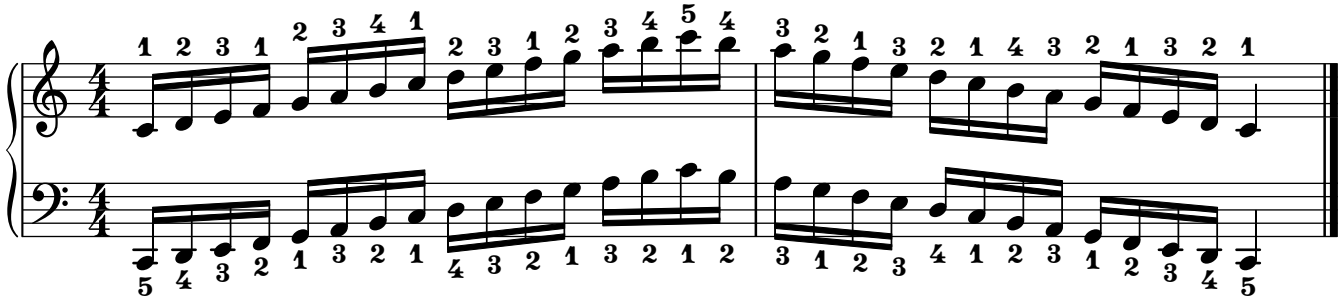
Stage 3 - With Volume 3

Two-octave scales, arpeggios and inversions

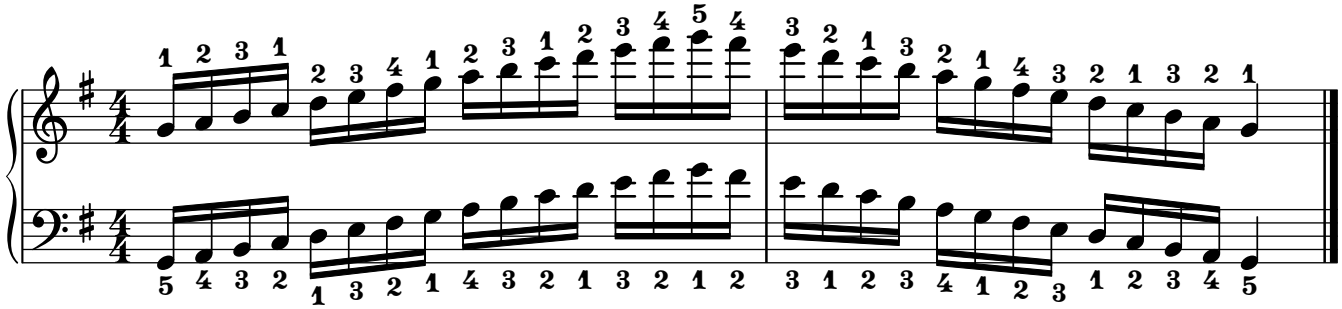
Keys up to two sharps or two flats. Scales two octaves, hands together an octave apart (in sixteenths: four notes to each metronome beat). Arpeggios in triplets: three notes to a beat.

Scales

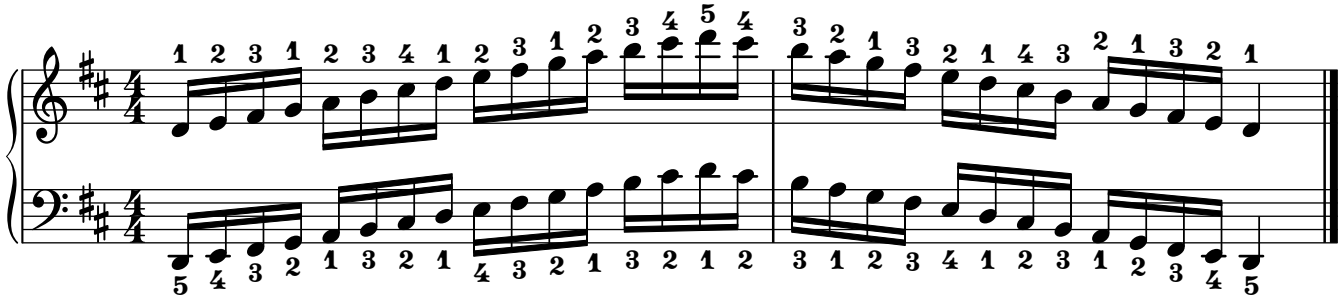
☐ **C major**



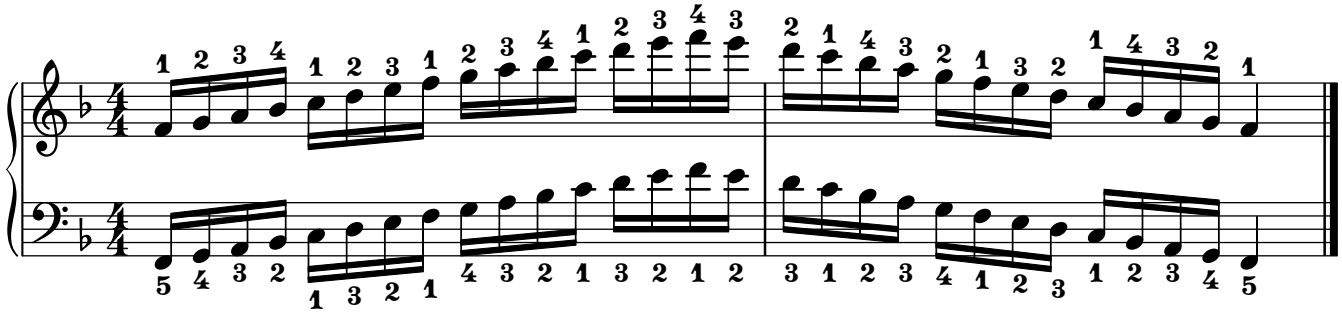
☐ **G major**



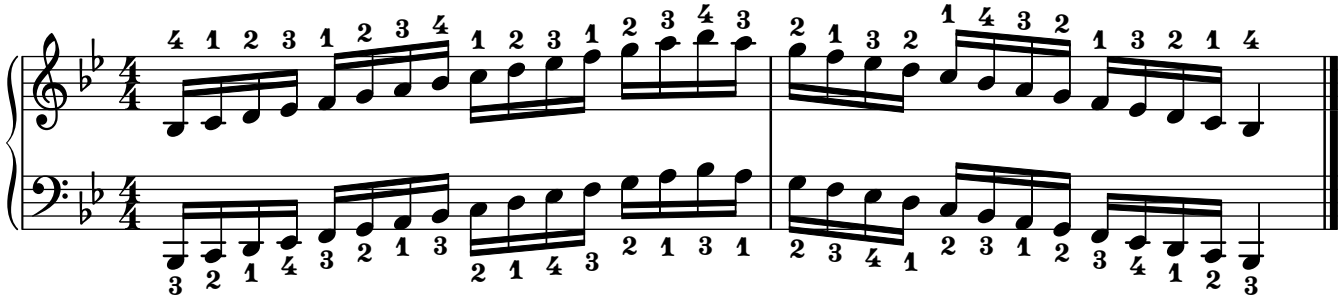
☐ **D major**



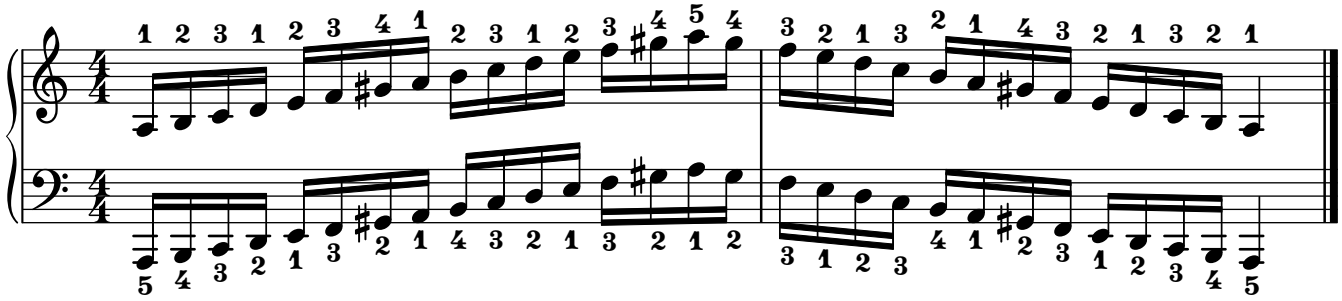
☐ **F major**



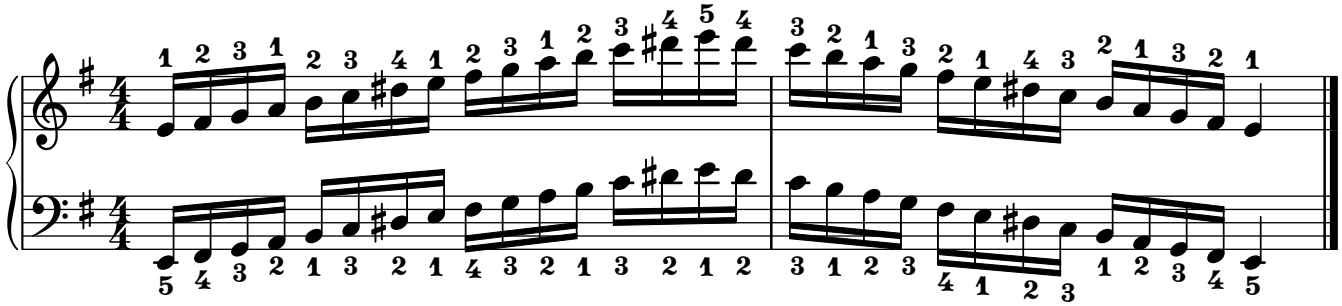
☐ **B-flat major**



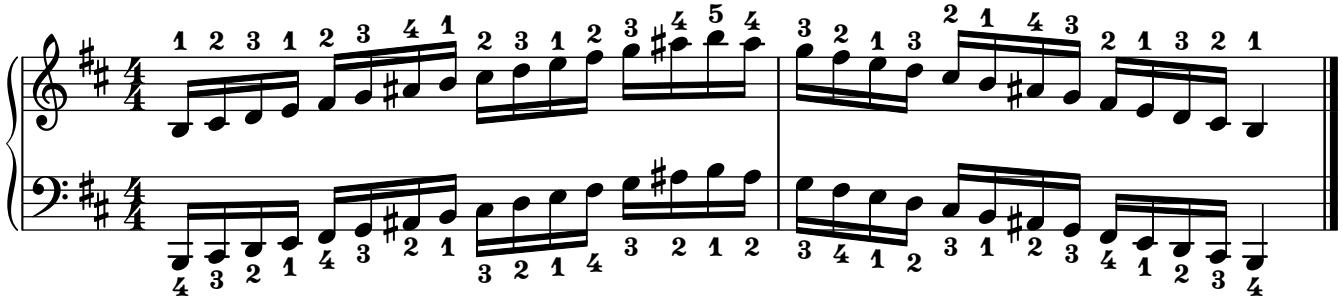
☐ **A minor (harmonic)**



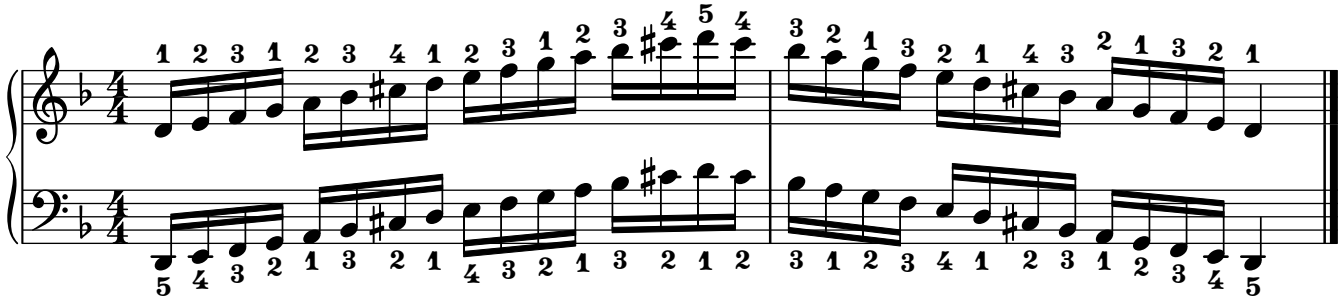
☐ **E minor (harmonic)**



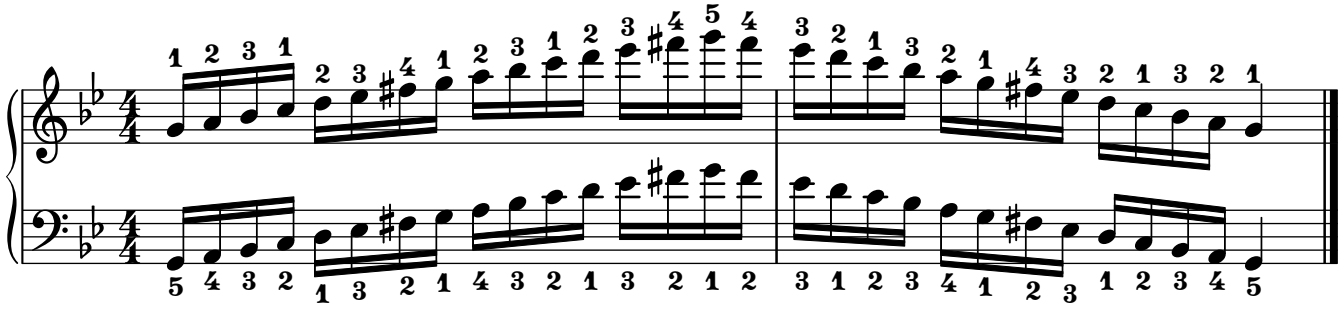
☐ **B minor (harmonic)**



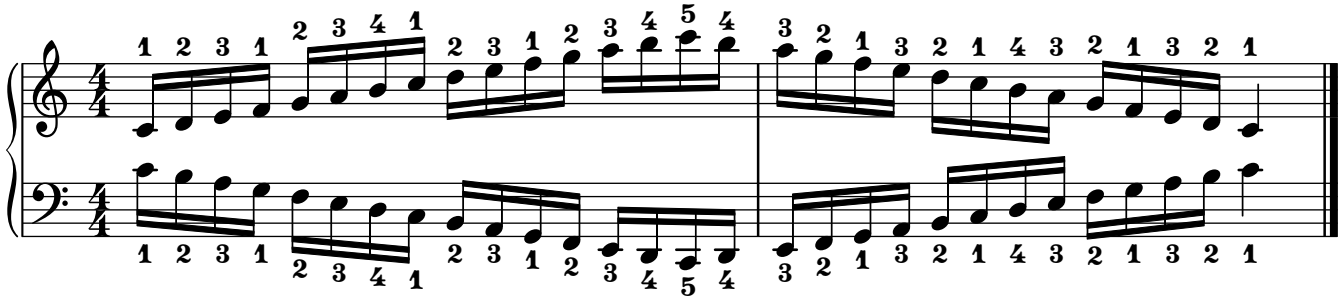
☐ **D minor (harmonic)**



☐ **G minor (harmonic)**

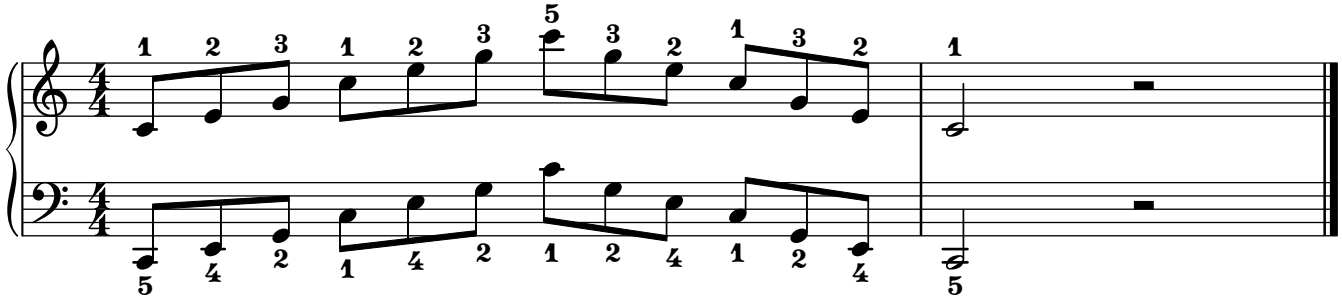


☐ **C major, contrary motion**

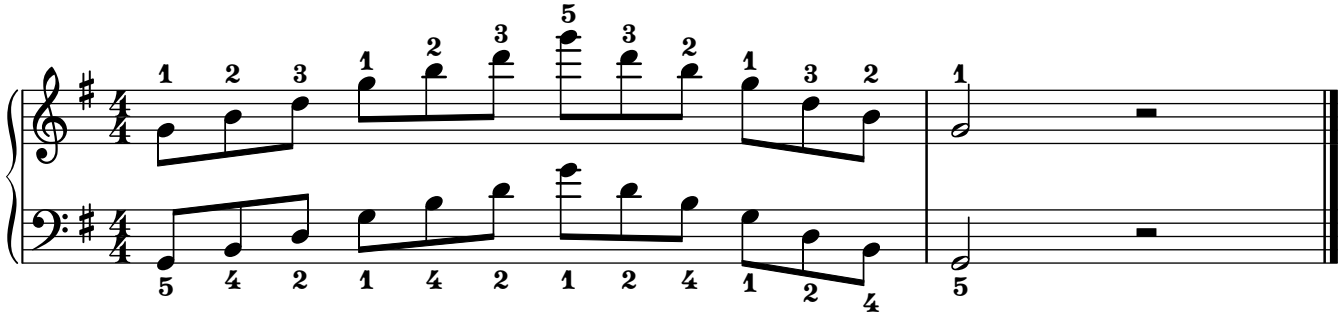


Arpeggios

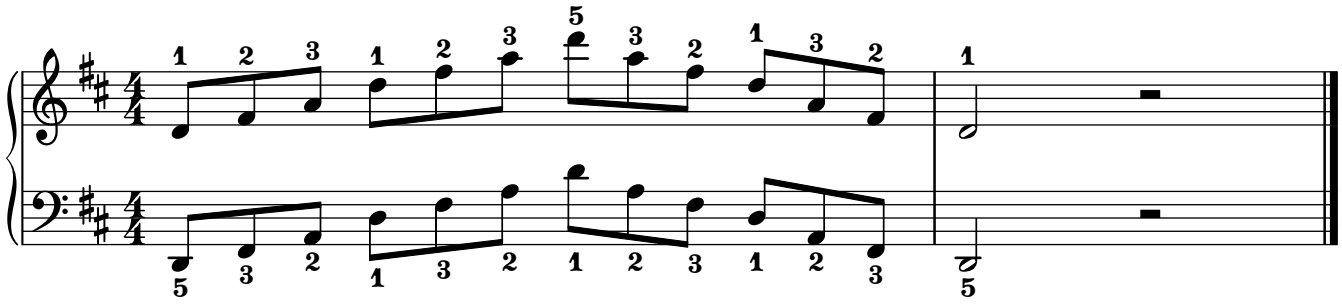
☐ **C major**



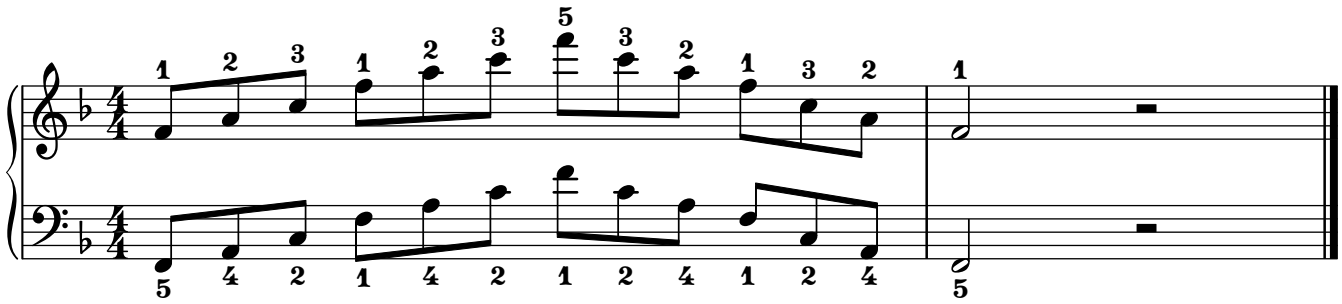
☐ **G major**



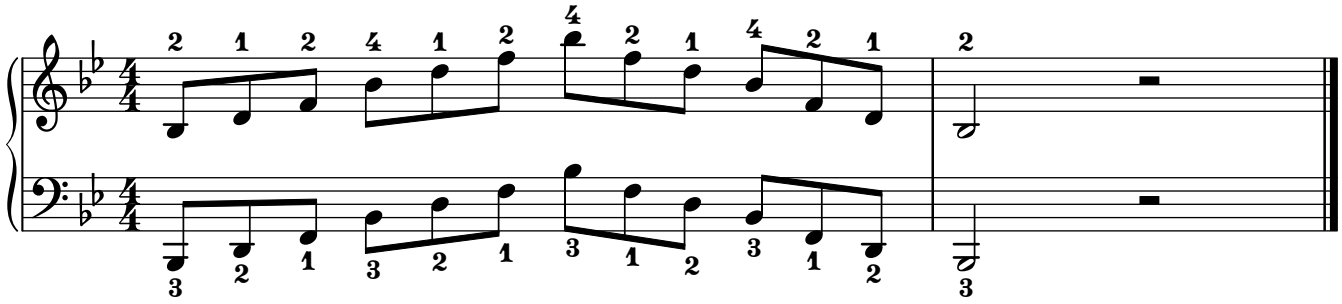
☐ **D major**



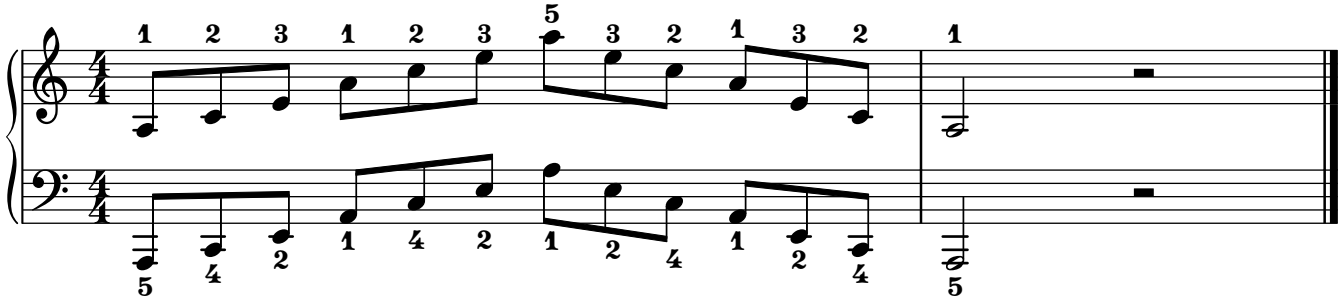
☐ **F major**



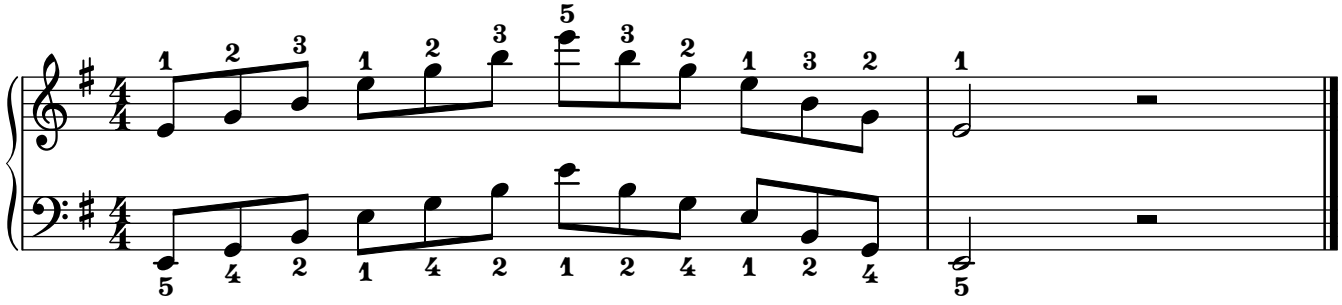
☐ **B-flat major**



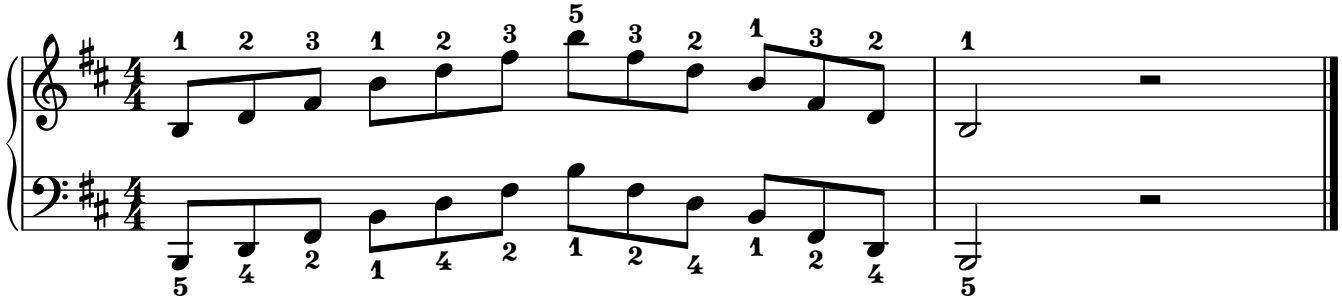
☐ **A minor**



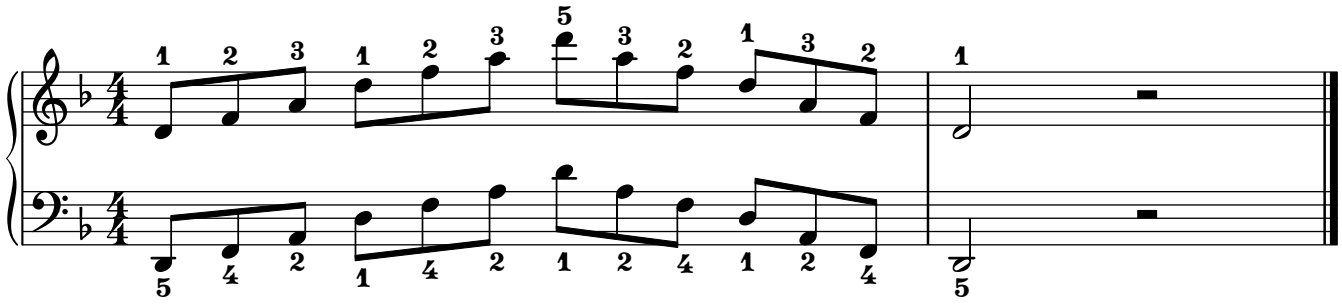
☐ **E minor**



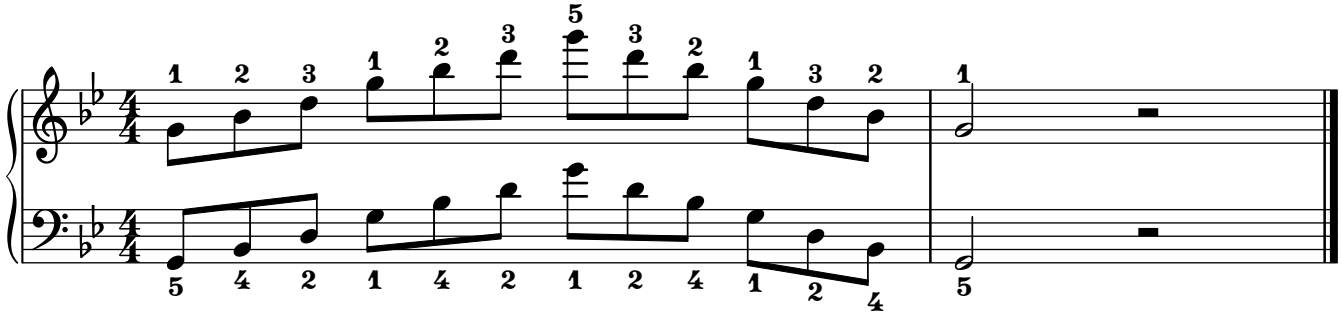
☐ **B minor**



☐ **D minor**

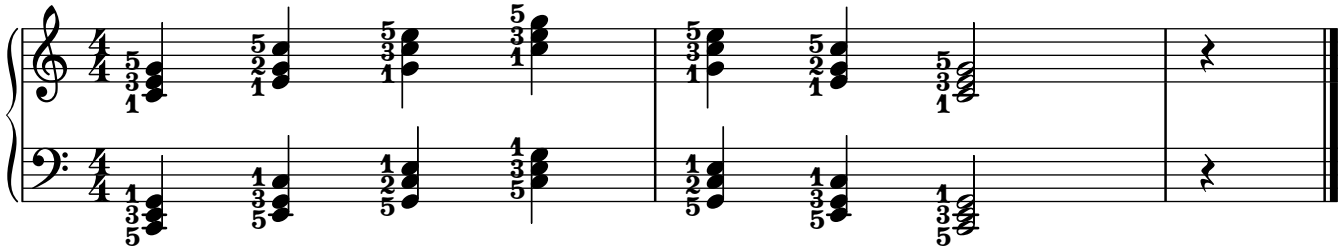


☐ **G minor**

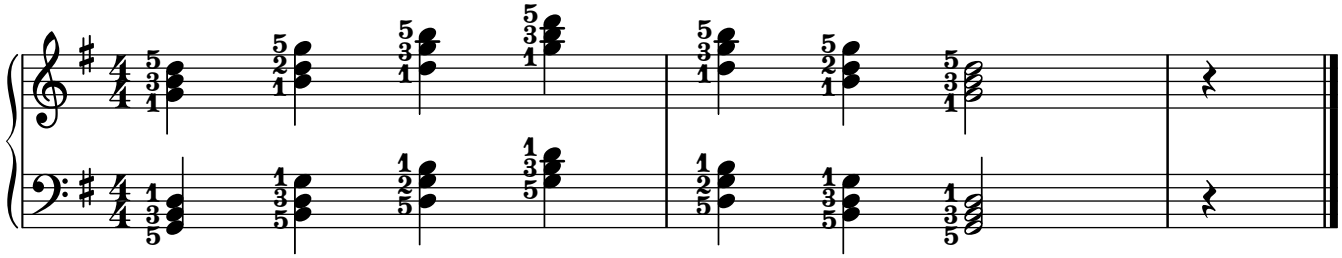


Triads and their inversions

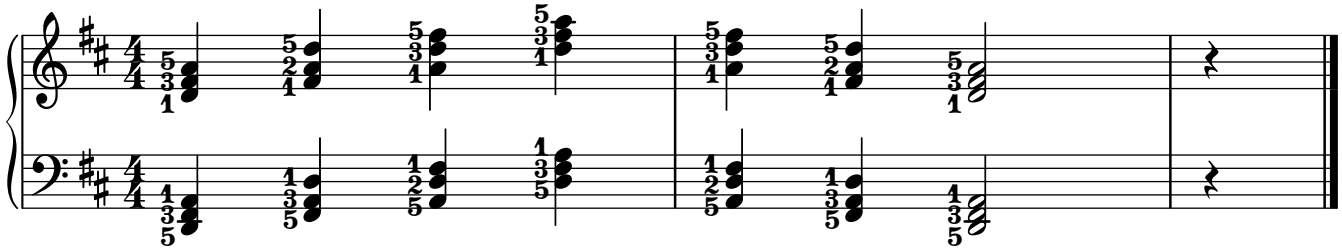
☐ **C major**



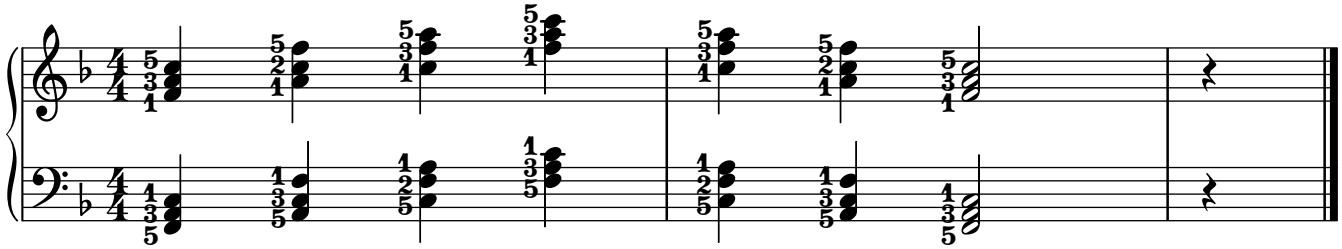
☐ **G major**



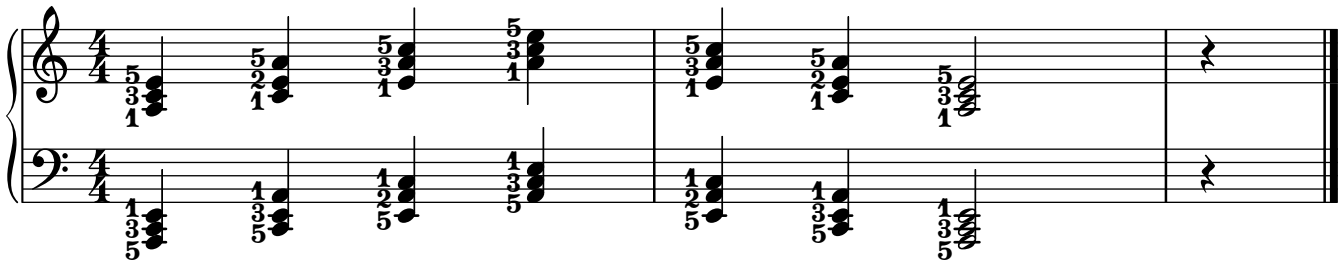
☐ **D major**



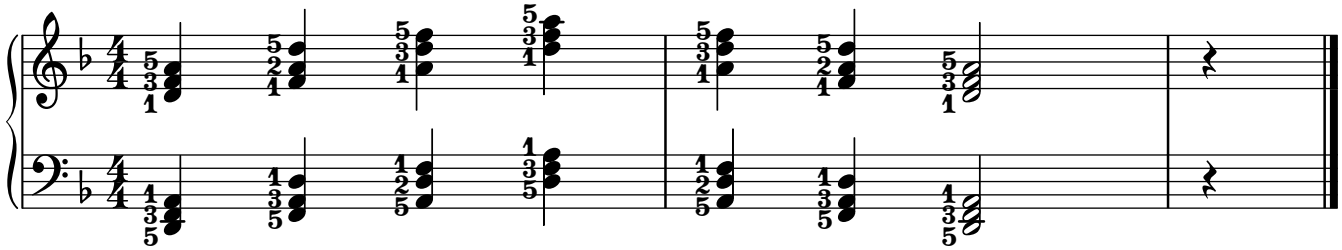
☐ **F major**



☐ **A minor**



☐ **D minor**



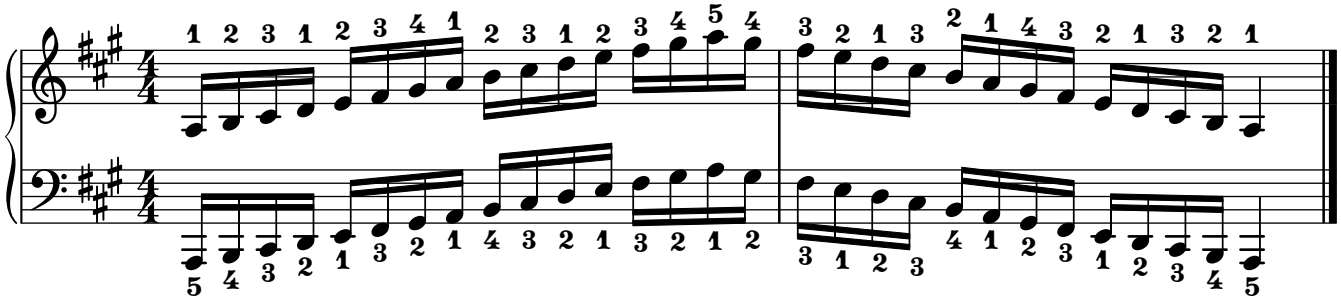
Stage 4 - With Volume 4

New keys, cadences, chromatic scale

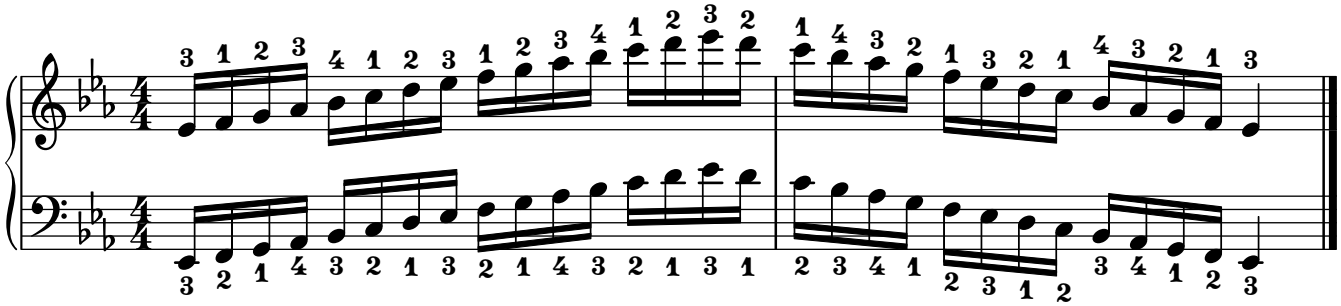
New keys up to three sharps or flats, the melodic minor (raised sixth and seventh going up, natural going down), the chromatic scale, and the cadence that ends most pieces: I - IV - I - V7 - I. In the cadences the right hand moves as little as possible; say the chord names as you play.

Scales

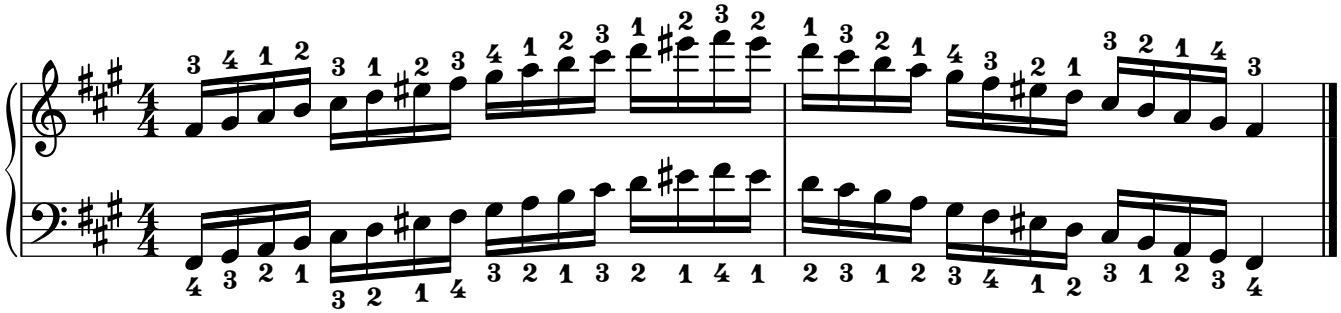
☐ **A major**



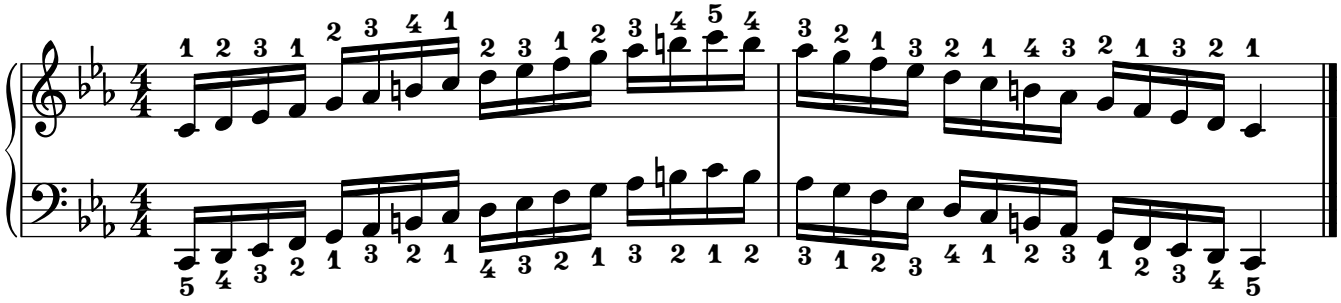
☐ **E-flat major**



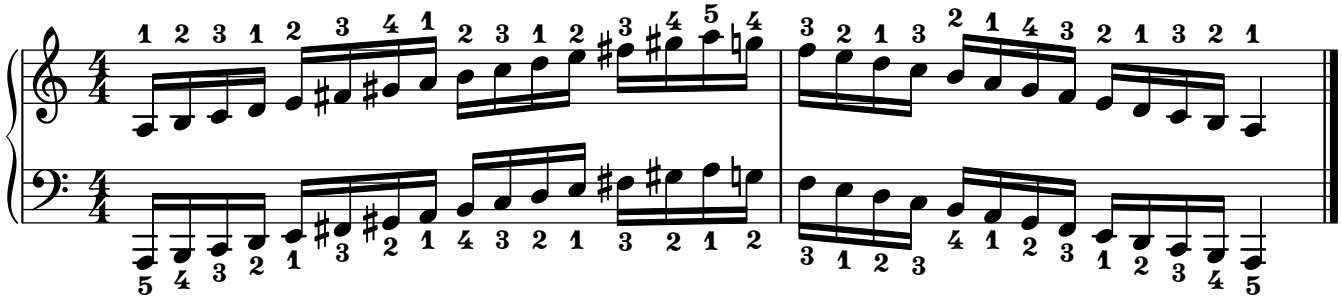
☐ **F-sharp minor (harmonic)**



☐ **C minor (harmonic)**



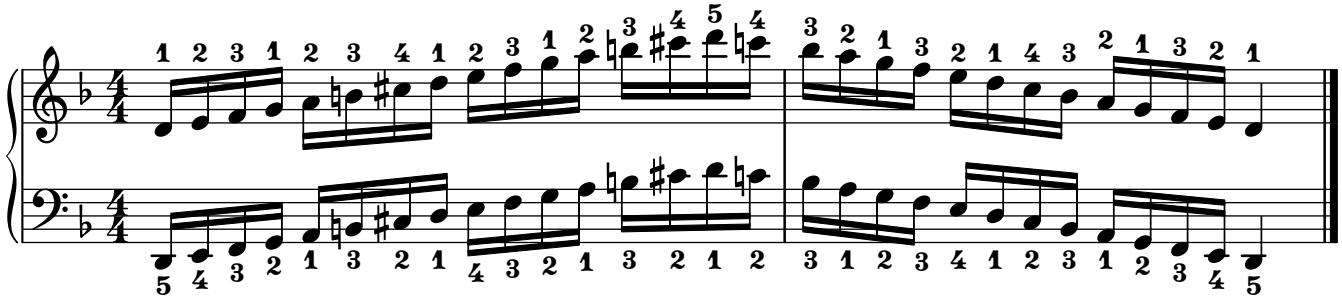
☐ **A minor (melodic)**



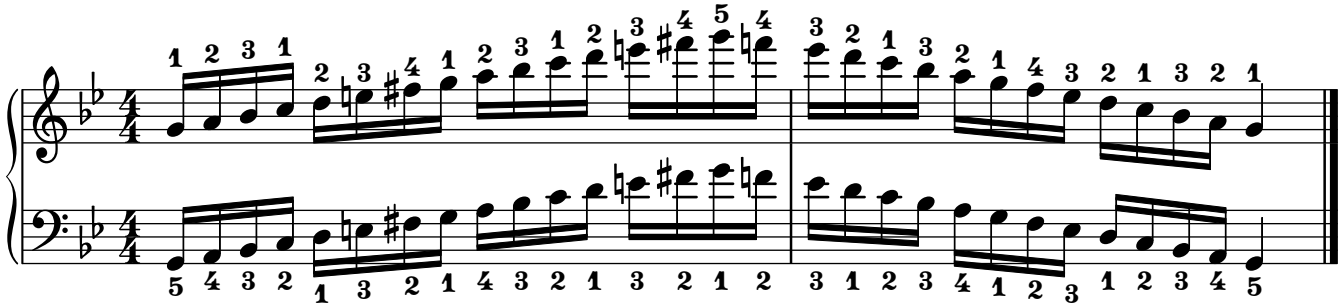
☐ **E minor (melodic)**



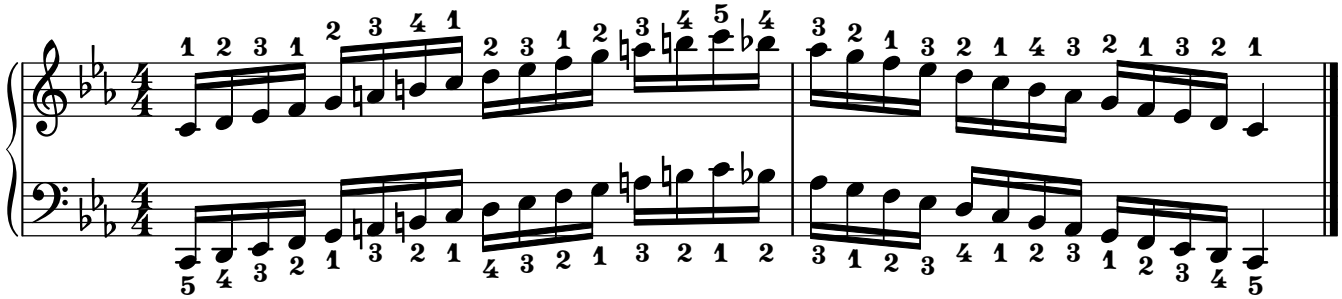
☐ **D minor (melodic)**



☐ **G minor (melodic)**



☐ **C minor (melodic)**

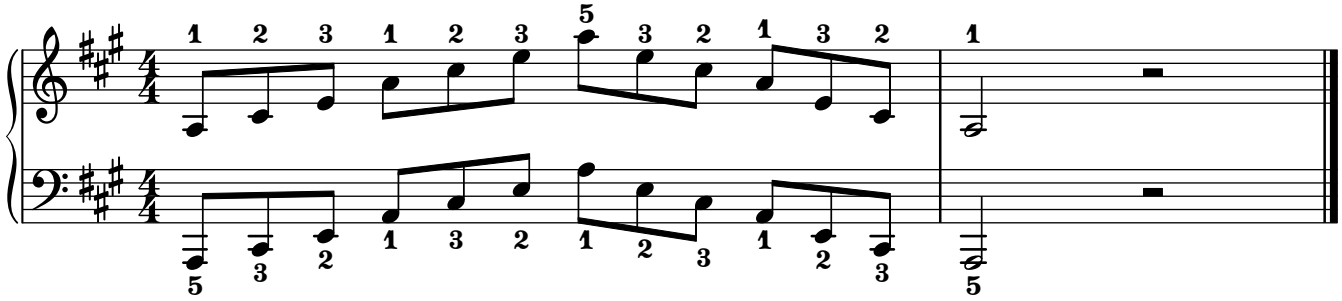


☐ **Chromatic scale from C, two octaves**

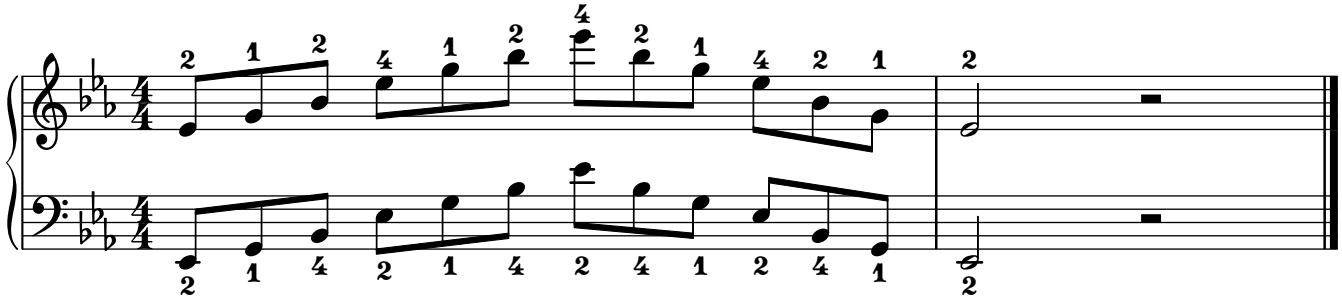


Arpeggios

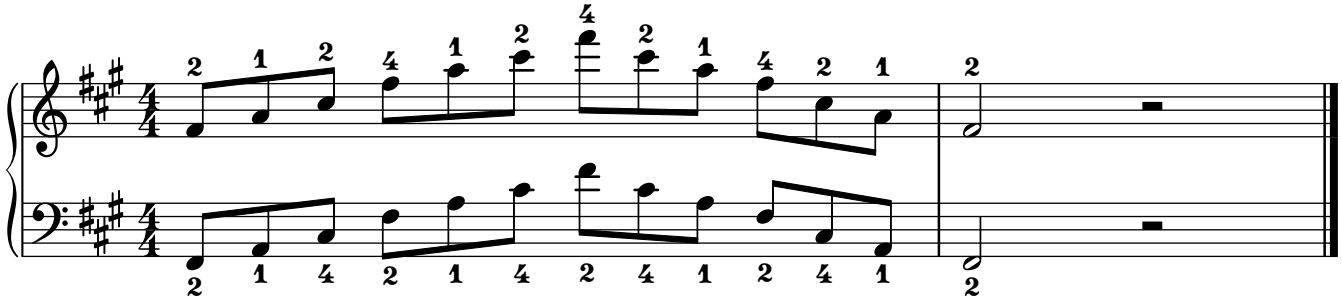
☐ **A major**



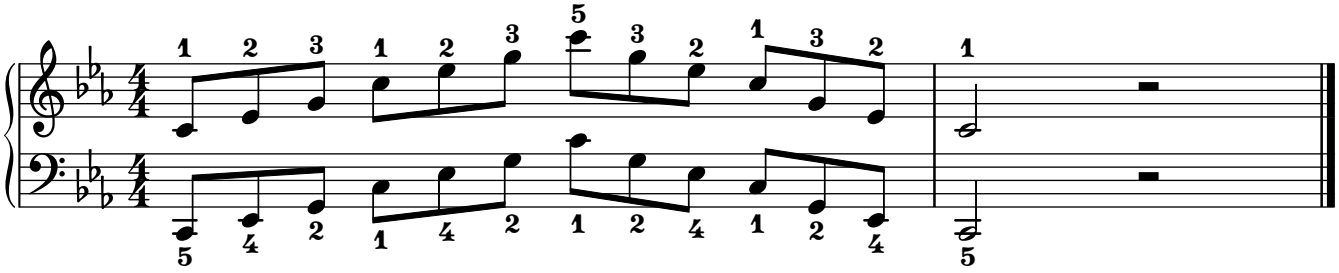
☐ **E-flat major**



☐ **F-sharp minor**

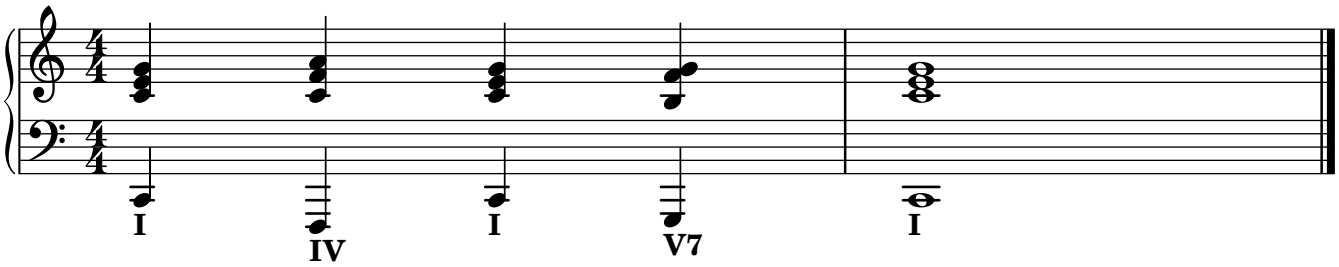


☐ **C minor**

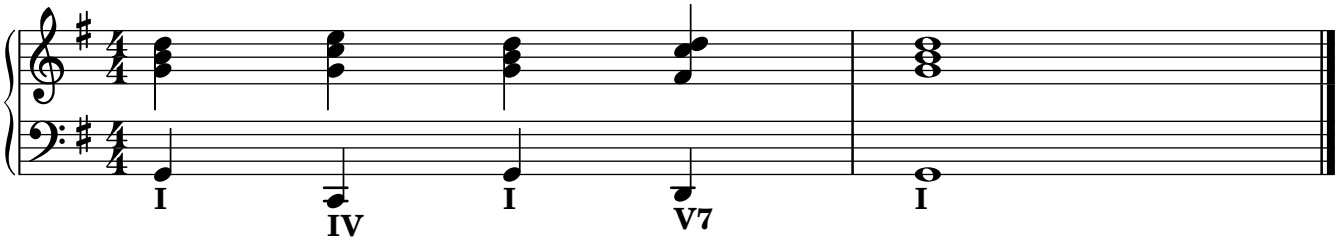


Cadences

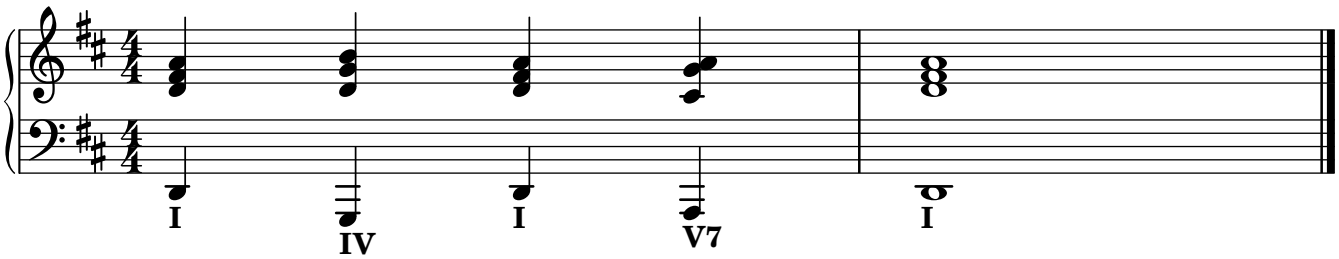
☐ **C major**



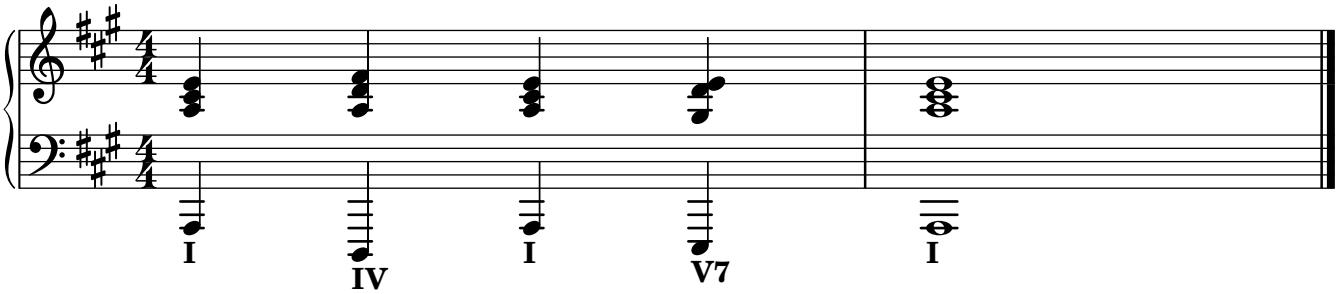
☐ **G major**



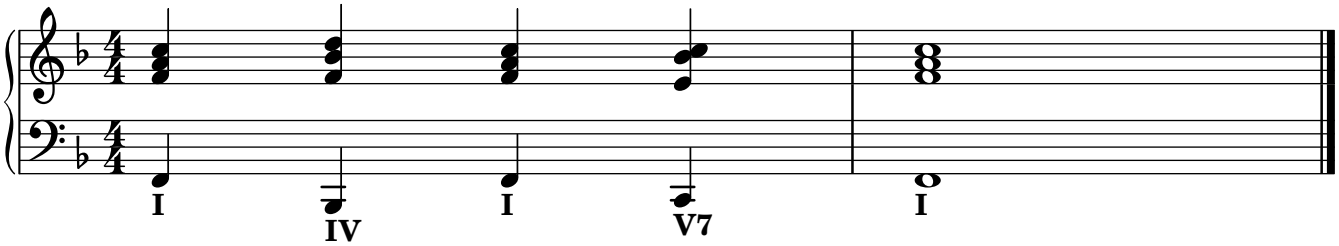
☐ **D major**



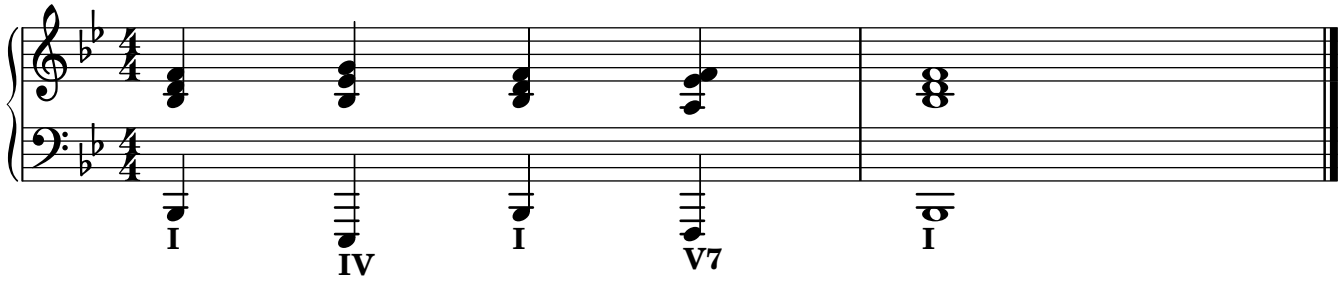
☐ **A major**



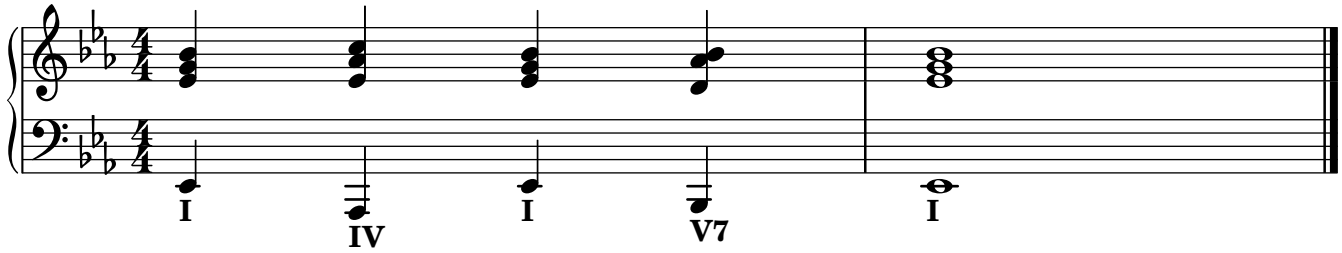
☐ **F major**



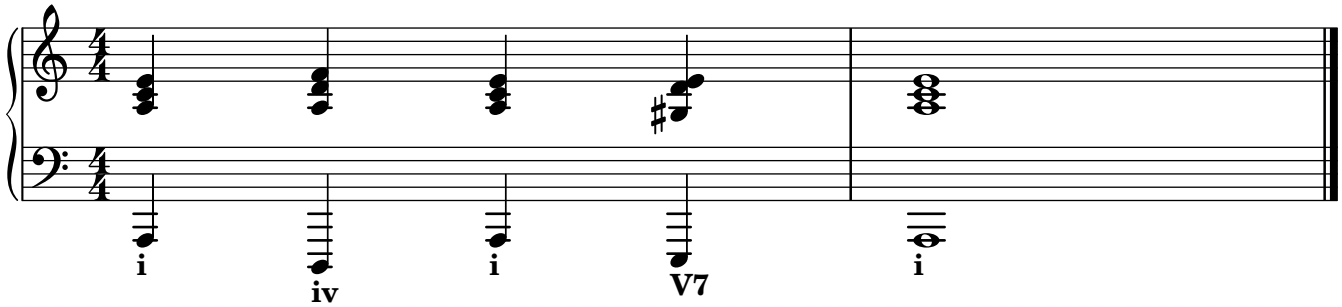
☐ **B-flat major**



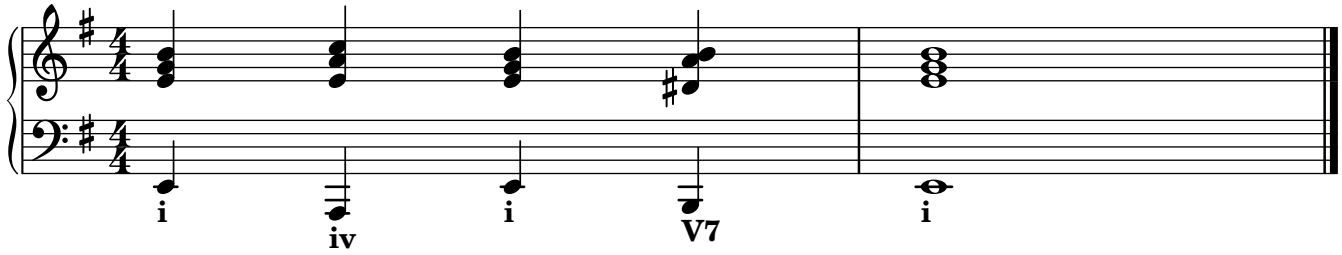
☐ **E-flat major**



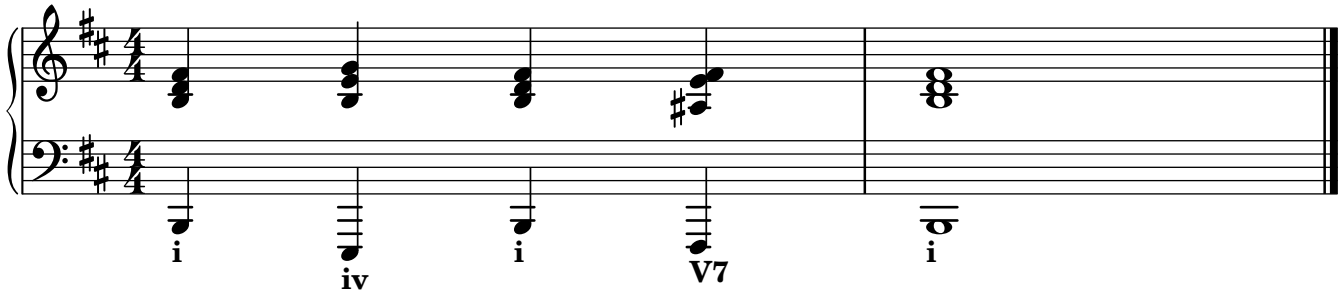
☐ **A minor**



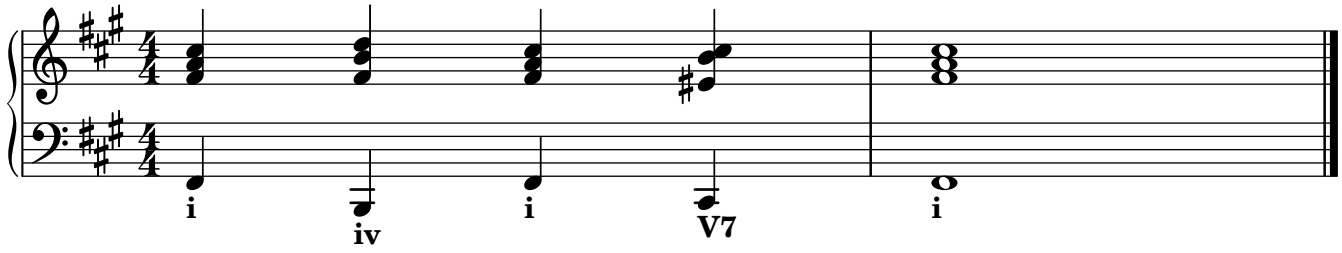
☐ **E minor**



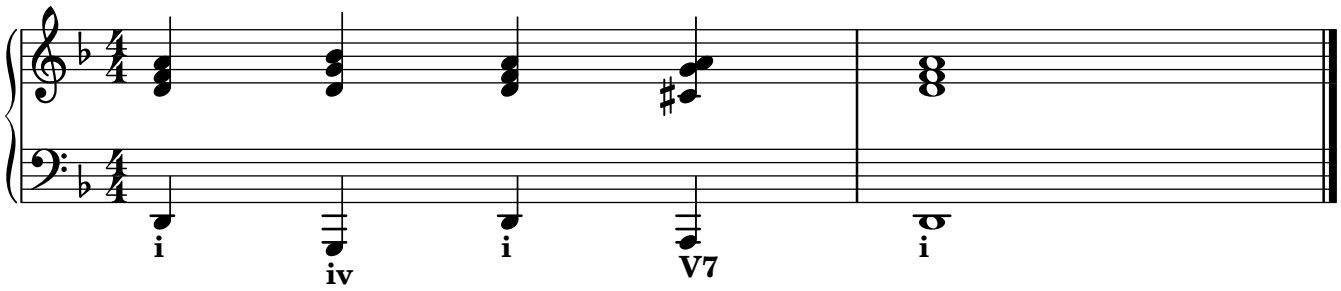
☐ **B minor**



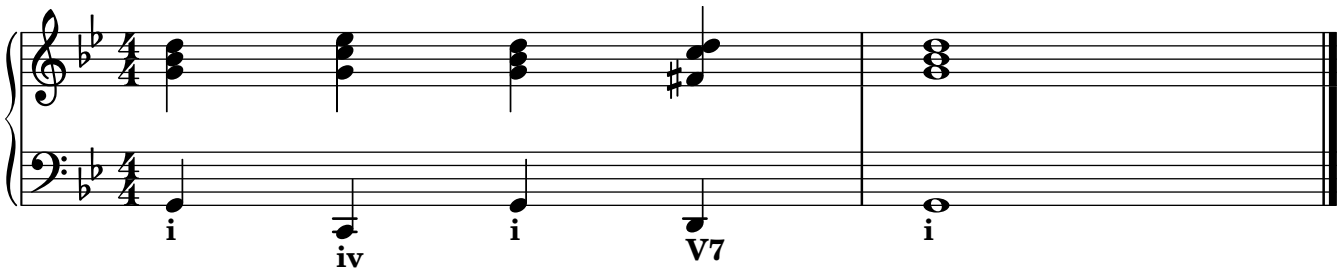
☐ **F-sharp minor**



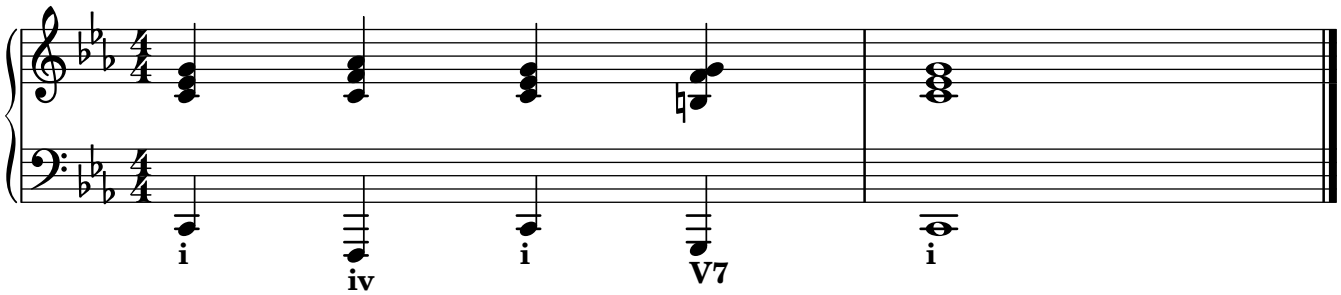
☐ **D minor**



☐ **G minor**



☐ **C minor**



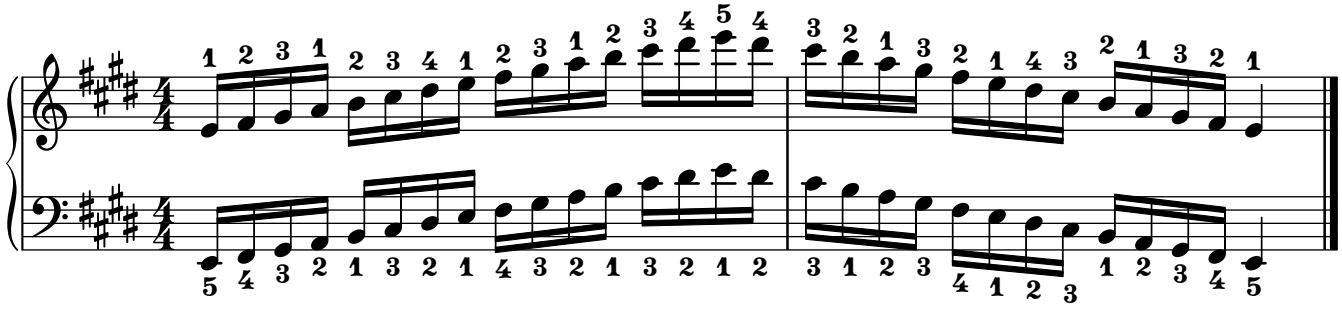
Stage 5 - With Volume 5

Every key

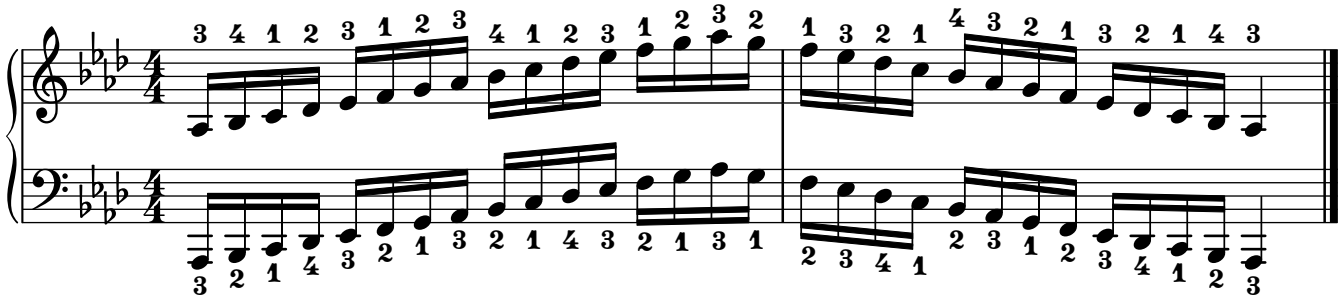
The remaining keys: four sharps and flats first (Volume 5, Unit 5), then the rest (Unit 6). With these, you have scales and arpeggios in all 24 keys; from now on, play the whole set round the circle of fifths, a few keys a day.

Scales

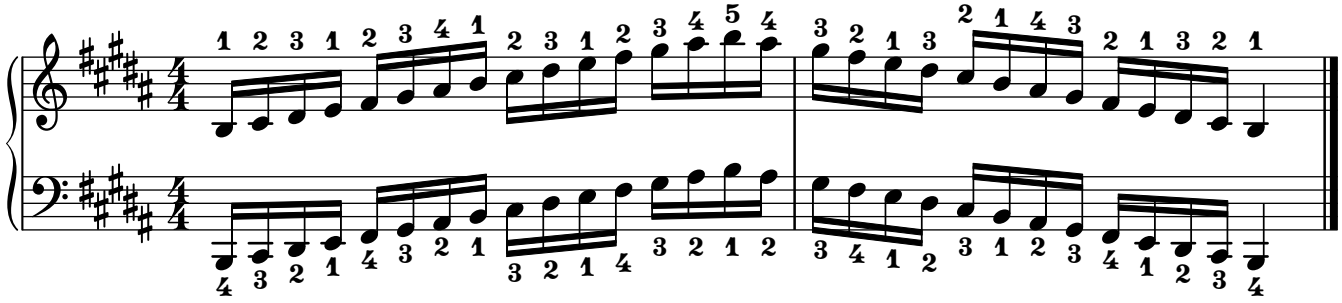
☐ **E major**



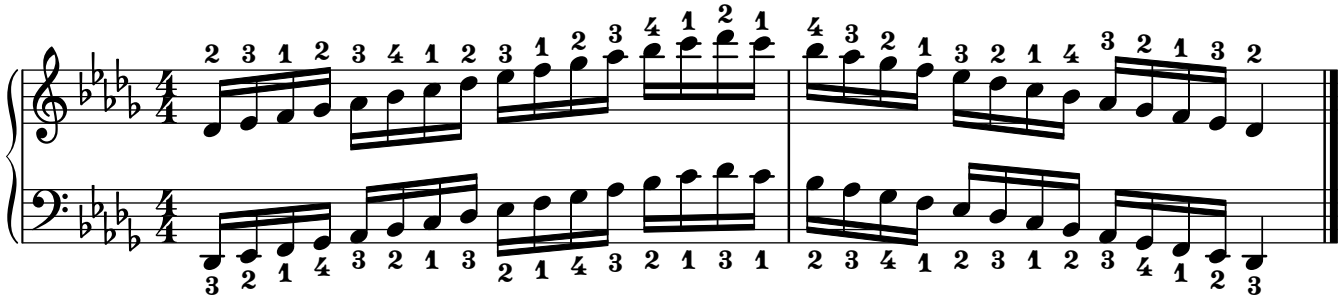
☐ **A-flat major**



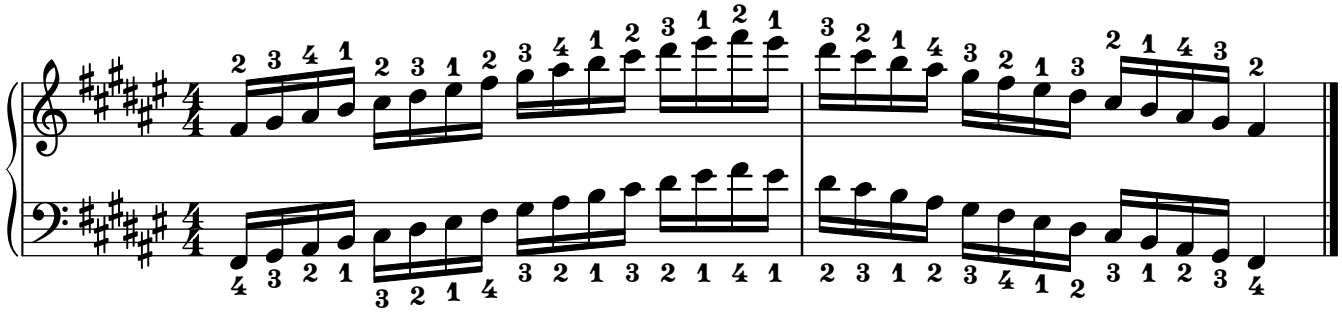
☐ **B major**



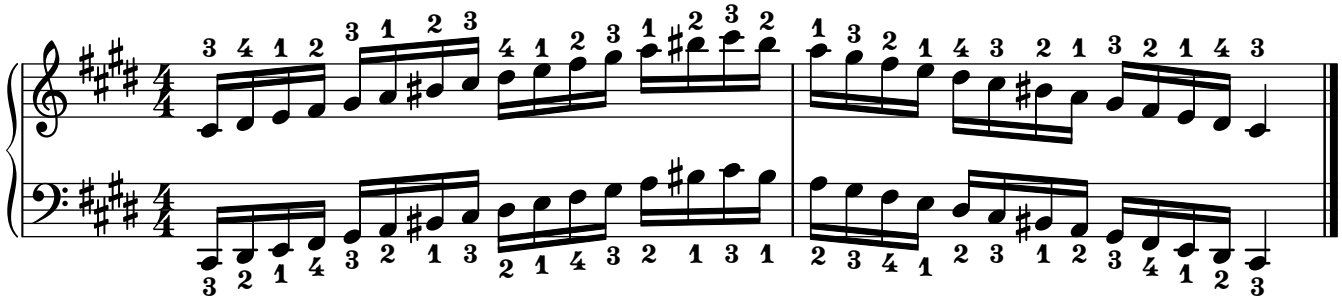
☐ **D-flat major**



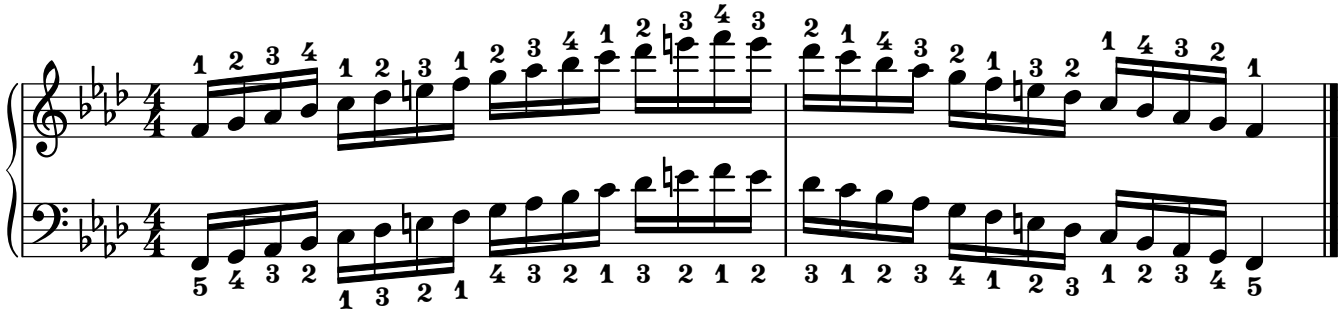
☐ **F-sharp major**



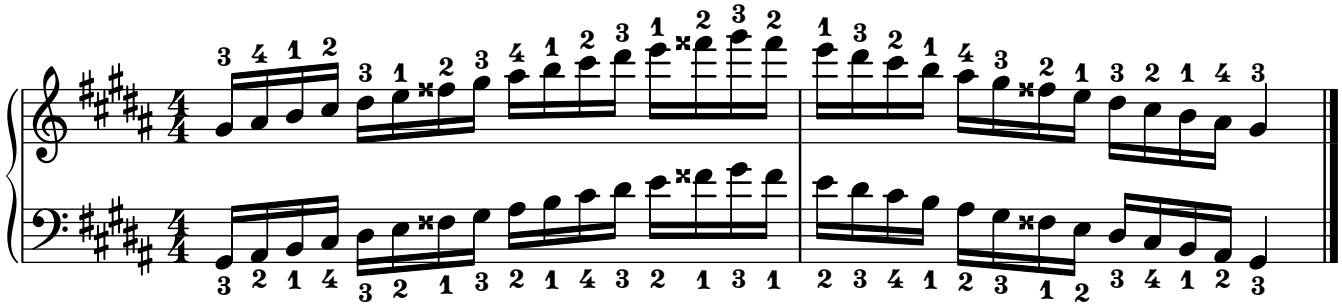
☐ **C-sharp minor (harmonic)**



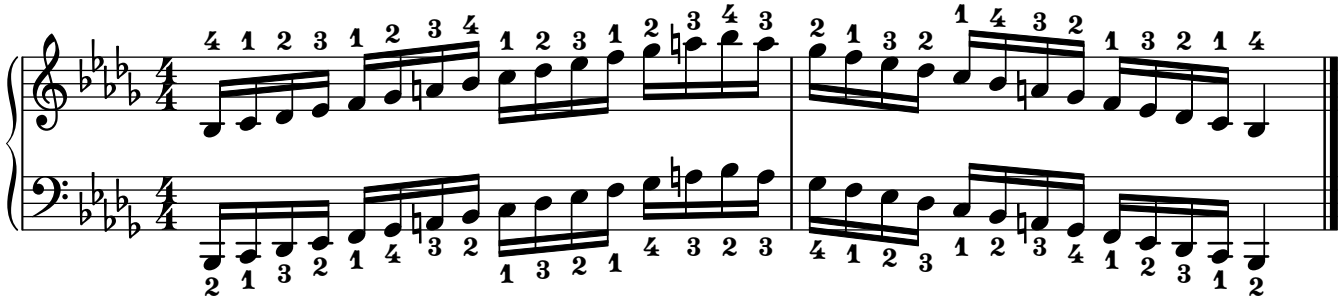
☐ **F minor (harmonic)**



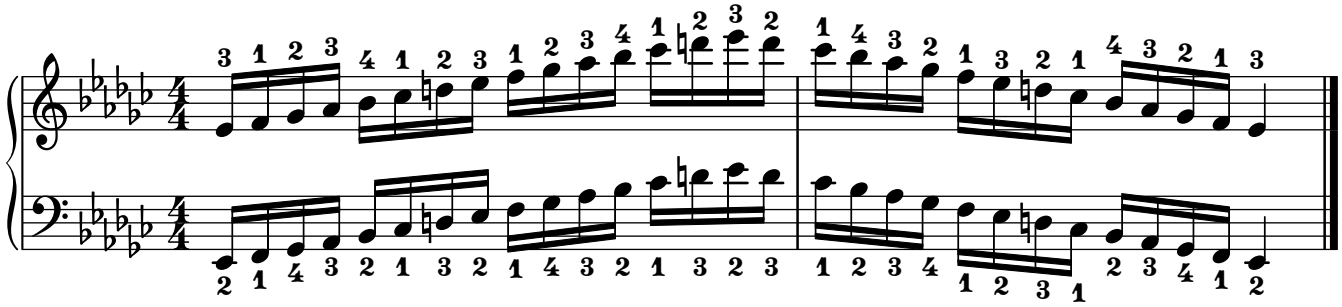
☐ **G-sharp minor (harmonic)**



☐ **B-flat minor (harmonic)**

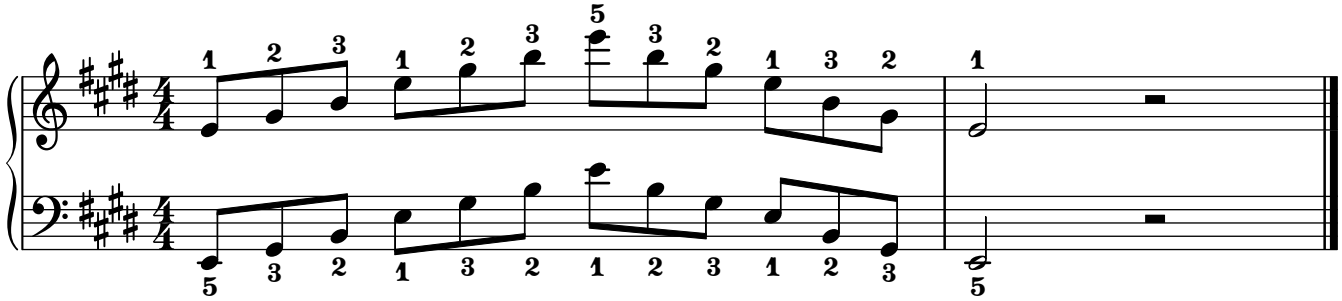


☐ **E-flat minor (harmonic)**

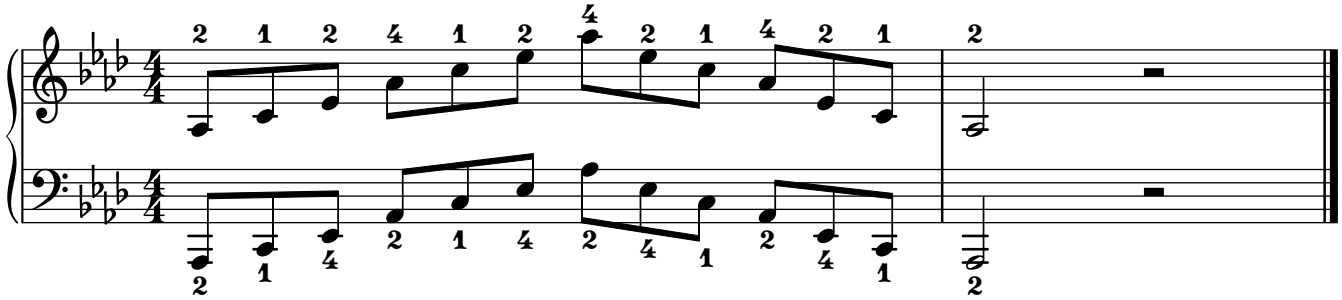


Arpeggios

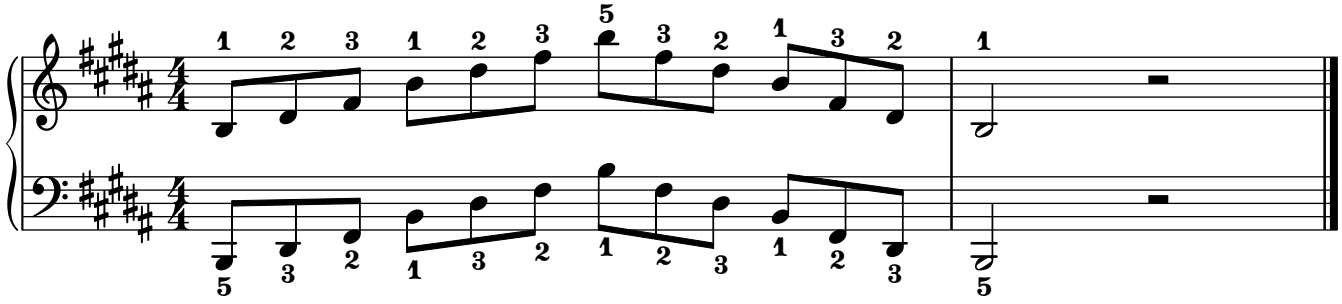
☐ **E major**



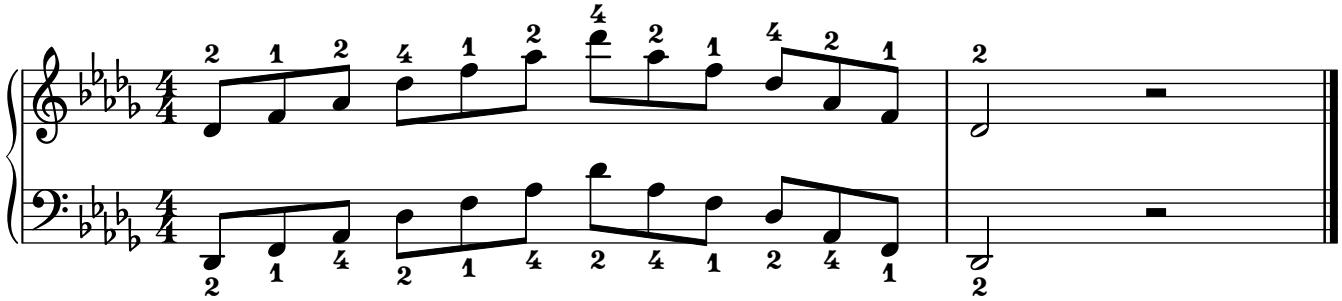
☐ **A-flat major**



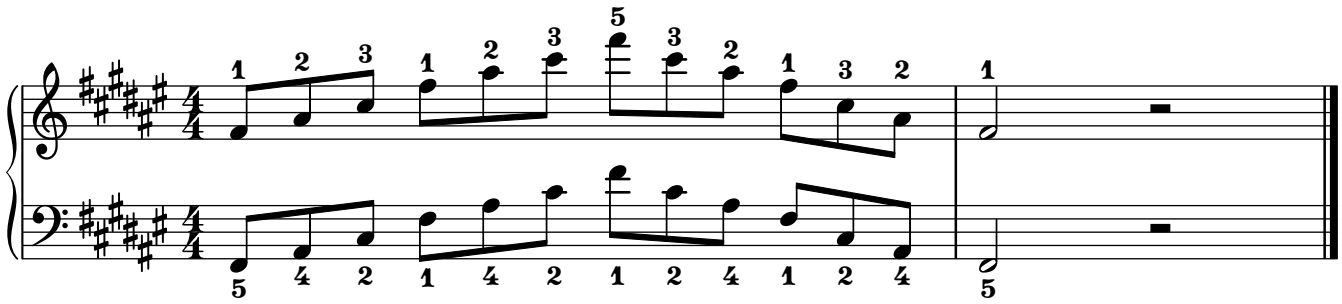
☐ **B major**



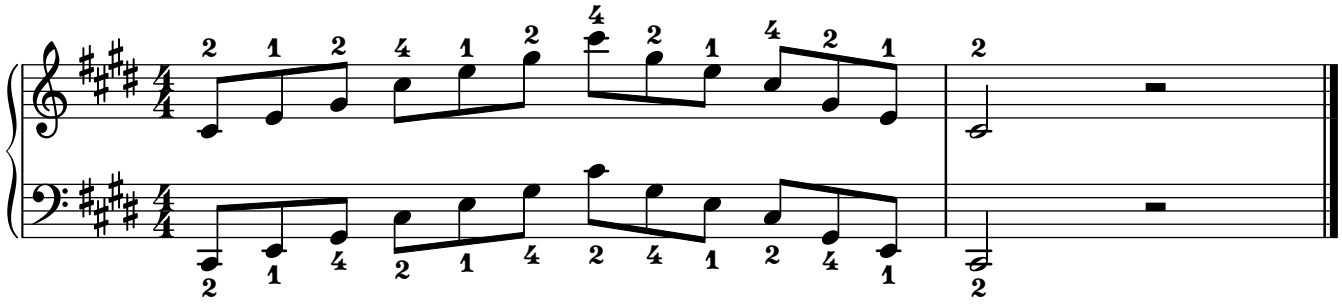
☐ **D-flat major**



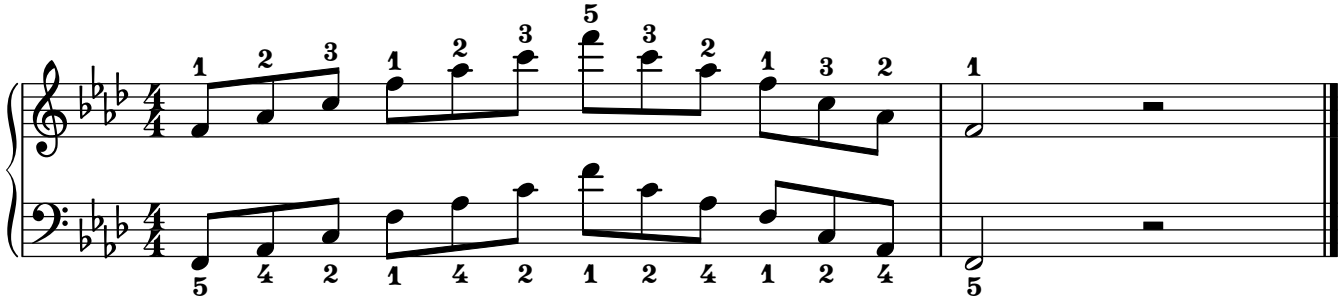
☐ **F-sharp major**



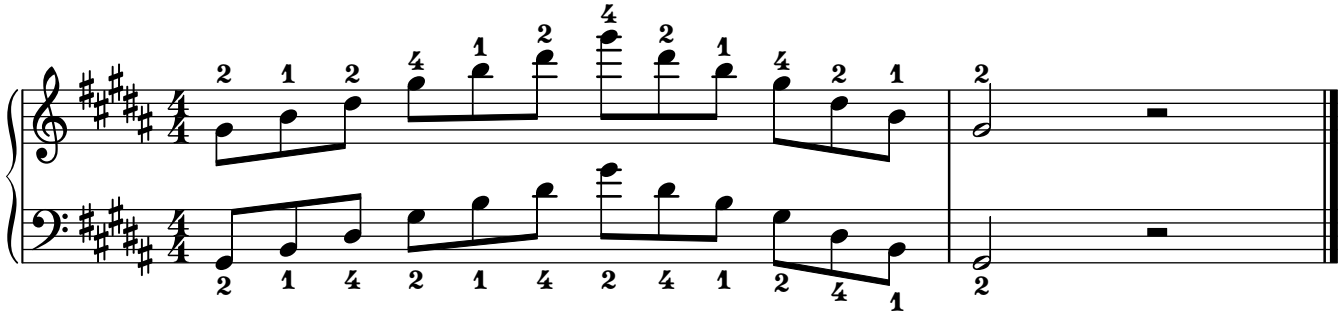
☐ **C-sharp minor**



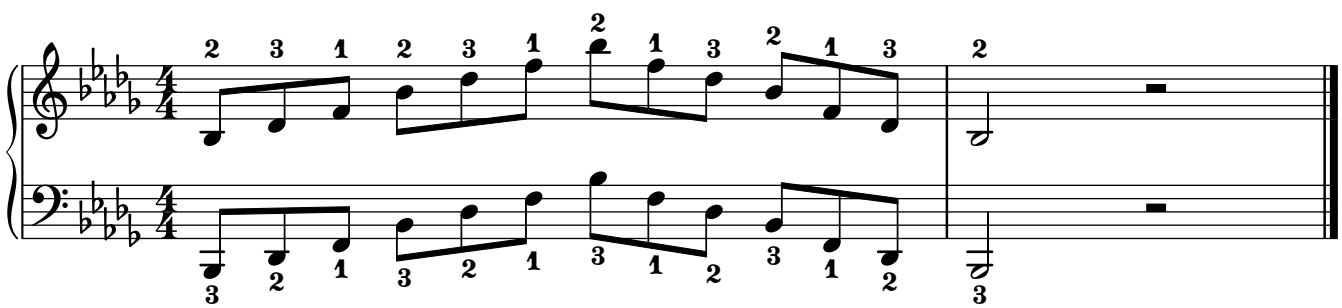
☐ **F minor**



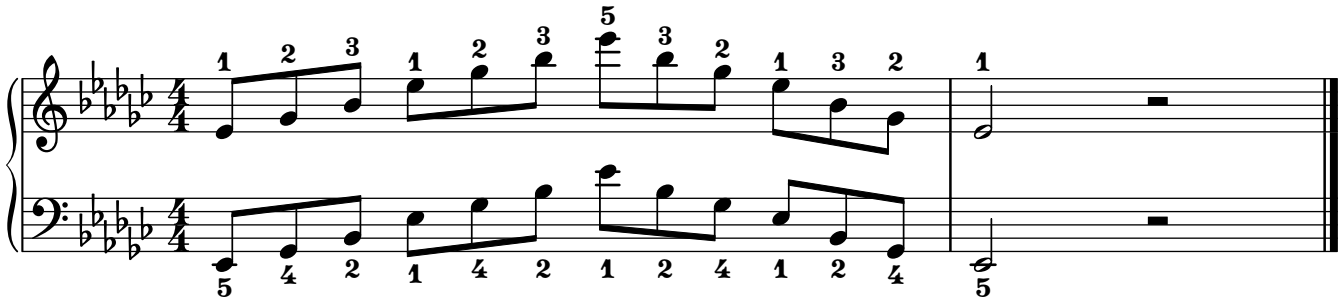
☐ **G-sharp minor**



☐ **B-flat minor**

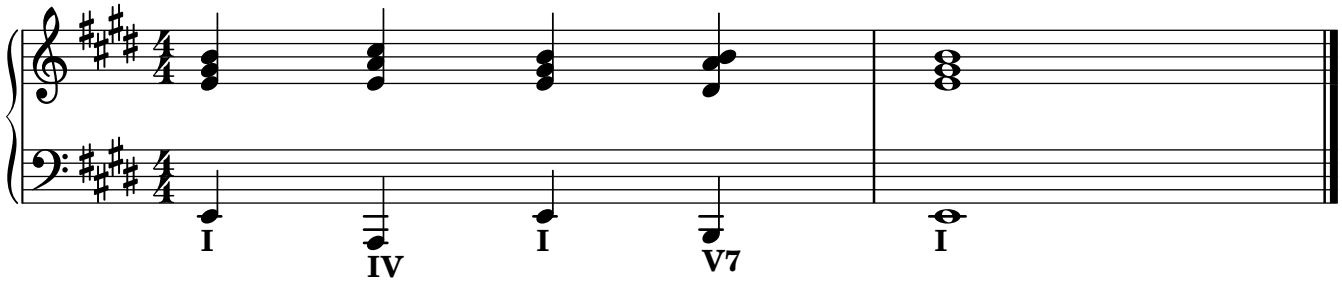


☐ **E-flat minor**

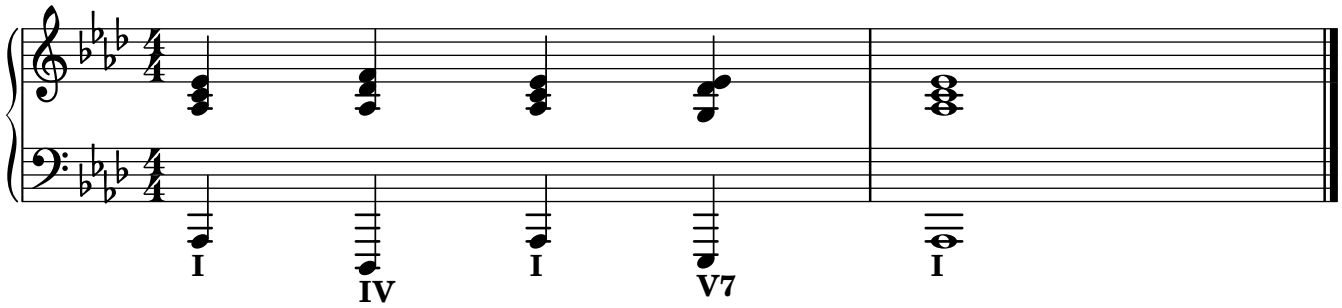


Cadences

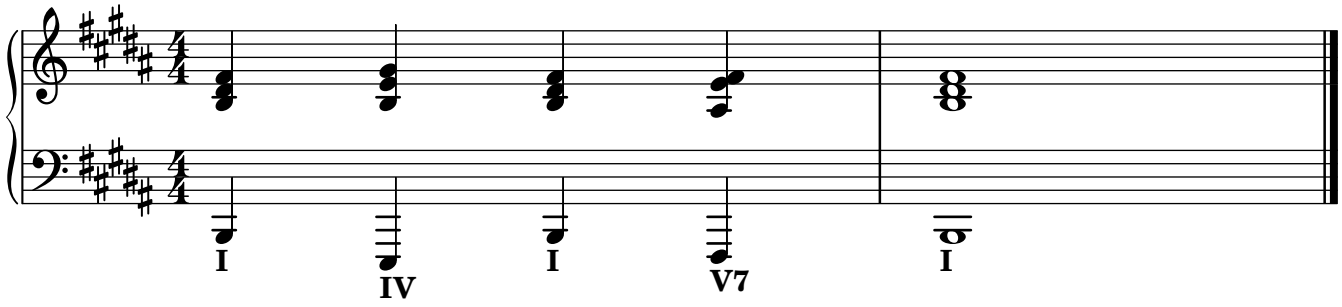
☐ **E major**



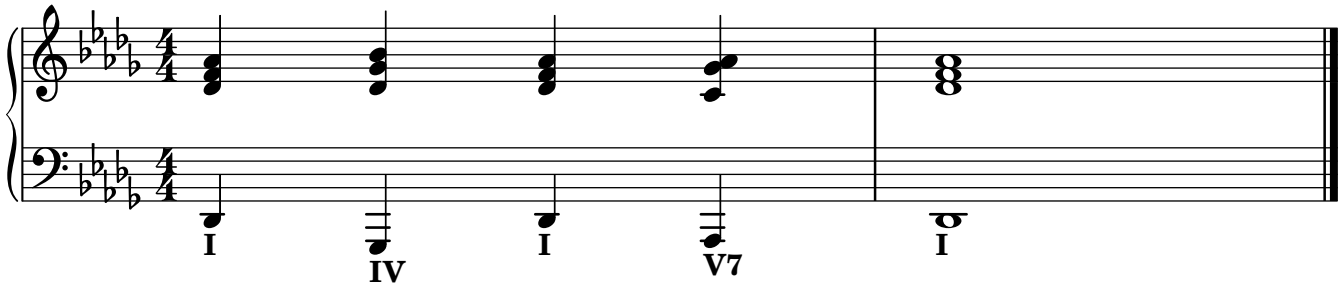
☐ **A-flat major**



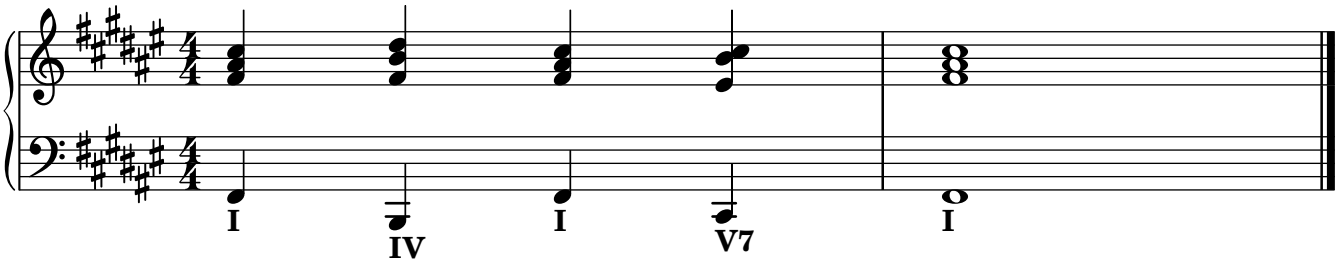
☐ **B major**



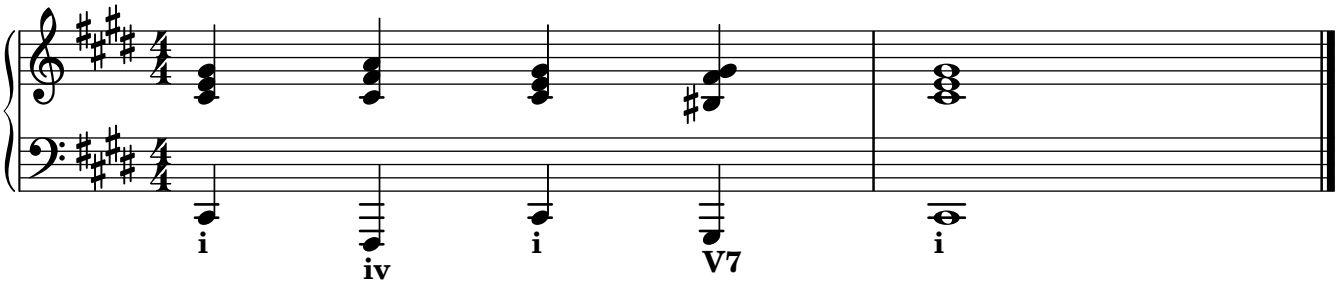
☐ **D-flat major**



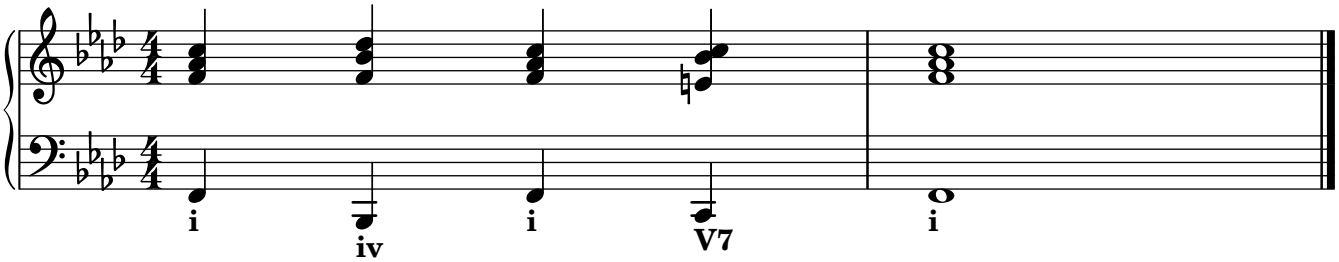
☐ **F-sharp major**



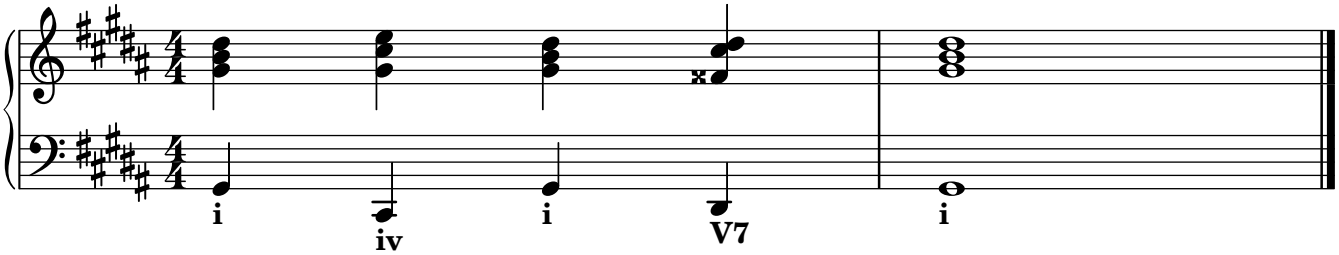
☐ **C-sharp minor**



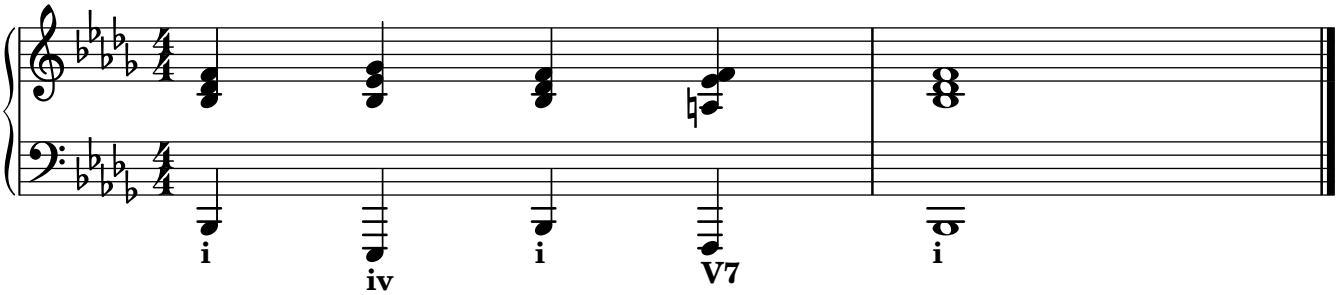
☐ **F minor**



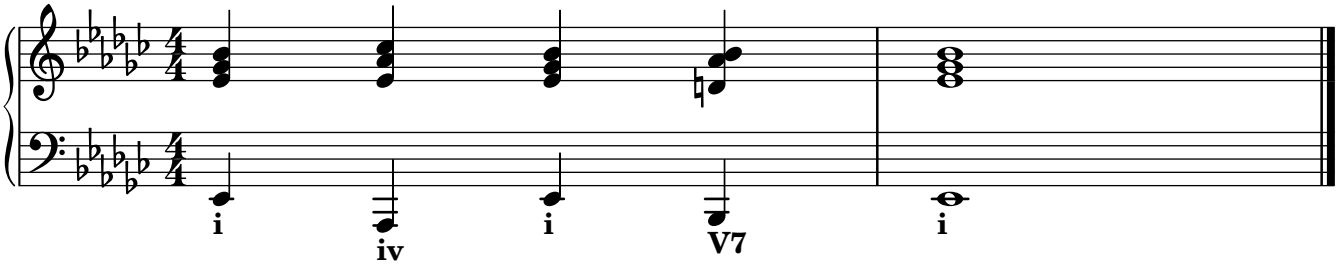
☐ **G-sharp minor**



☐ **B-flat minor**



☐ **E-flat minor**



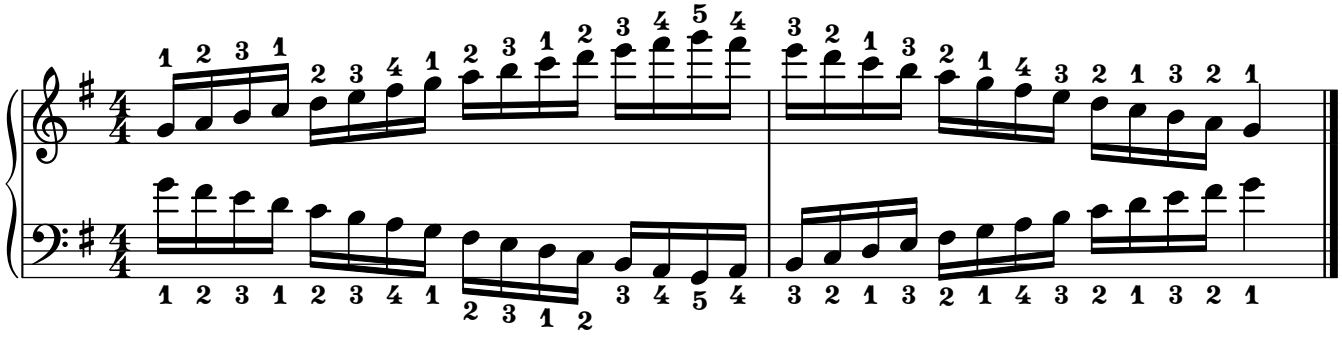
Stage 6 - With Volumes 6 and 7

Contrary motion and inverted arpeggios

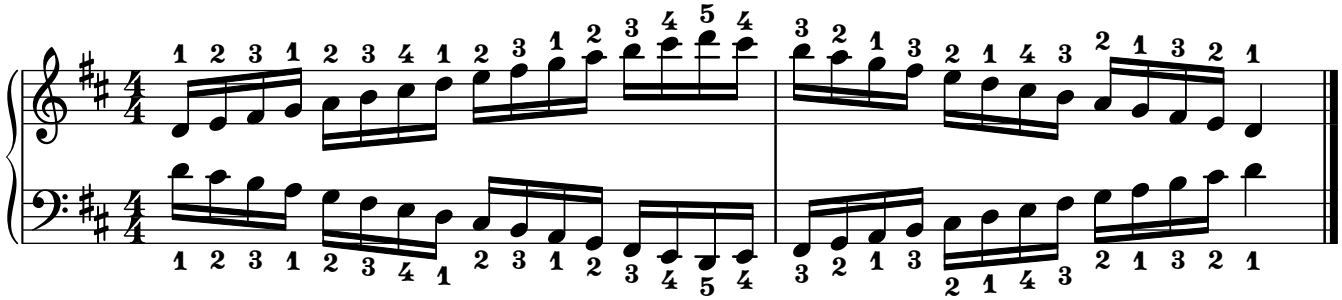
Scales in contrary motion (both hands start on the same key-note and move away from each other, each with its own fingering) and arpeggios starting on the third and fifth of the chord. Keep playing all 24 scales and arpeggios round the circle, and raise the speed slowly.

Contrary motion

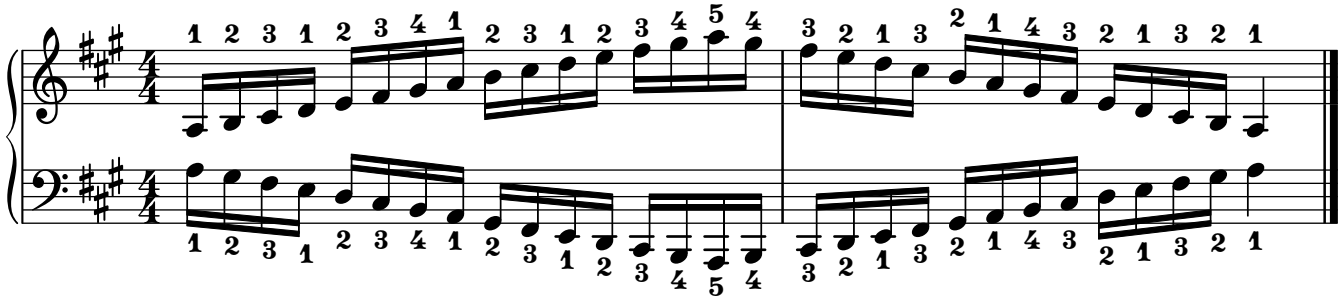
☐ **G major, contrary motion**



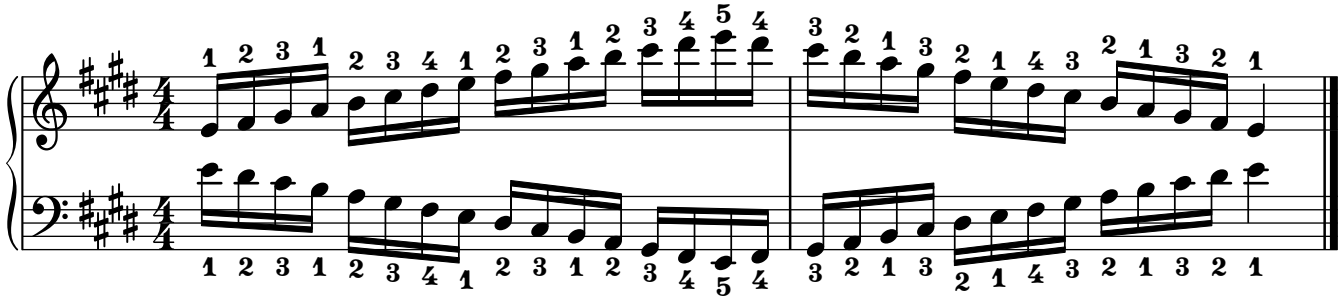
☐ **D major, contrary motion**



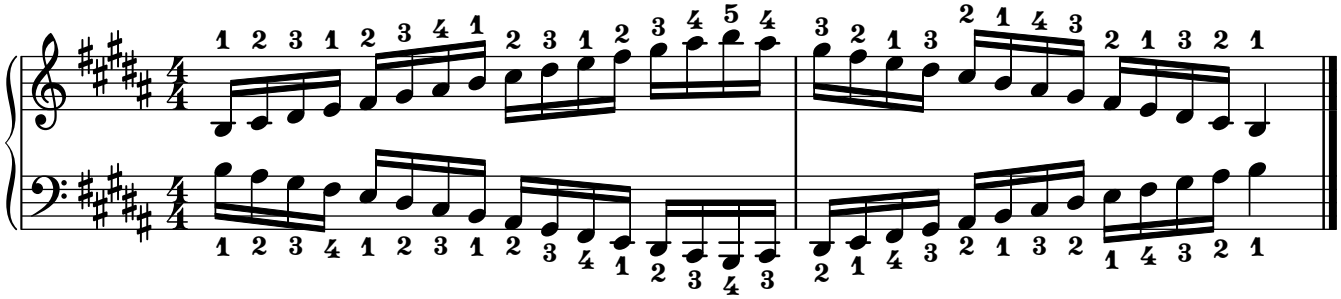
☐ **A major, contrary motion**



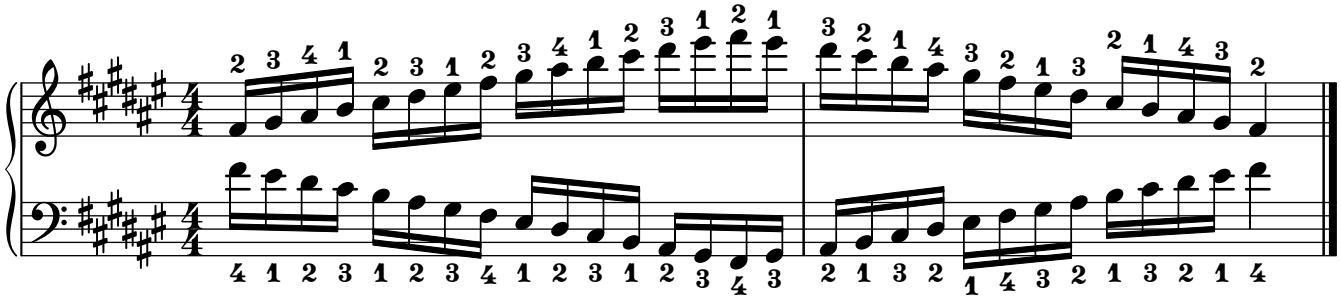
☐ **E major, contrary motion**



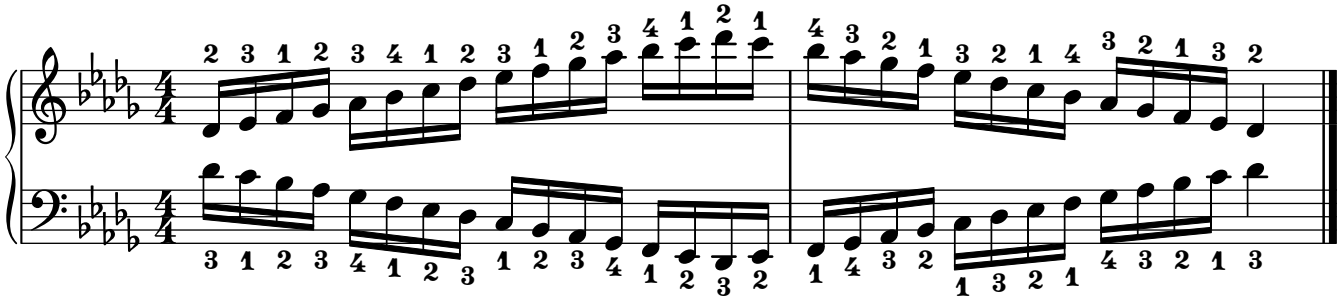
☐ **B major, contrary motion**



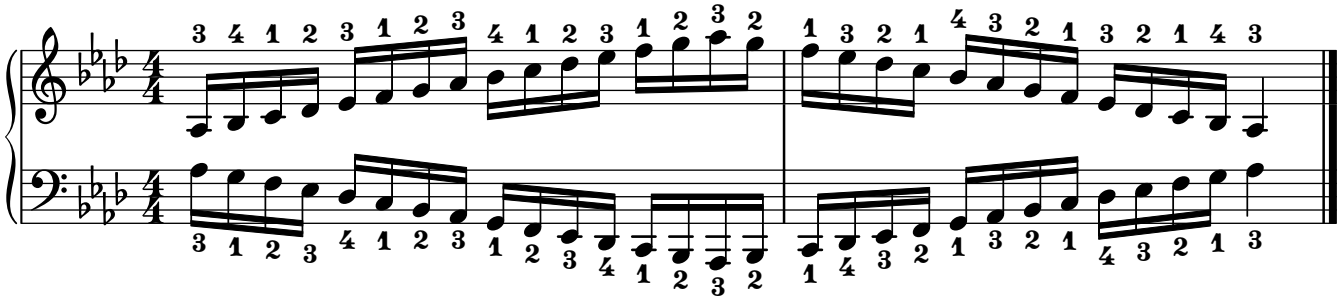
☐ **F-sharp major, contrary motion**



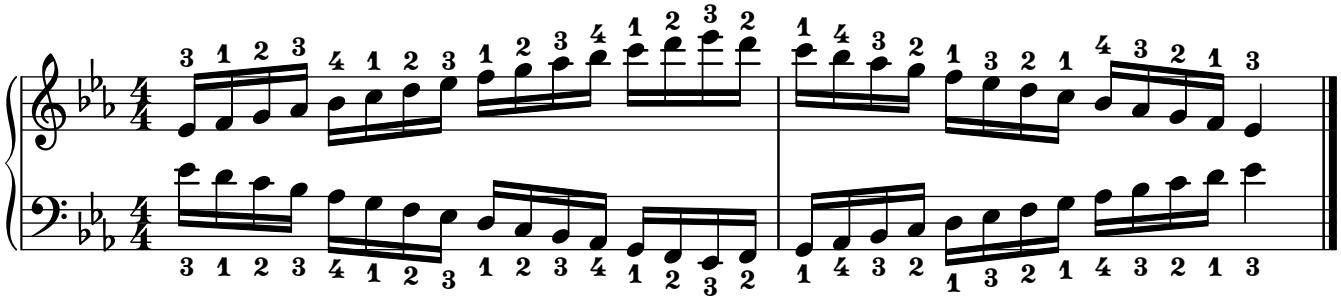
☐ **D-flat major, contrary motion**



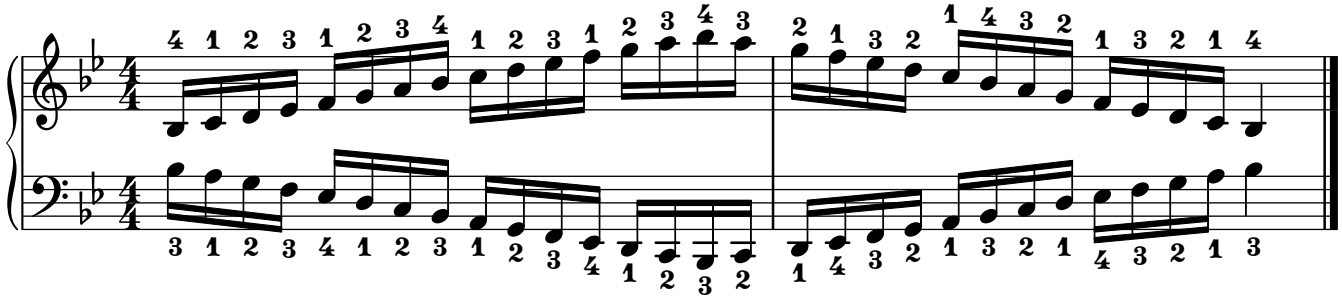
☐ **A-flat major, contrary motion**



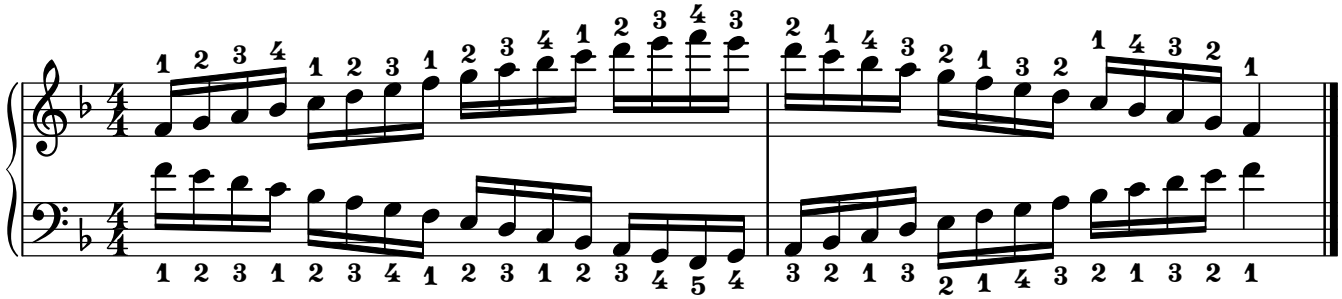
☐ **E-flat major, contrary motion**



☐ **B-flat major, contrary motion**

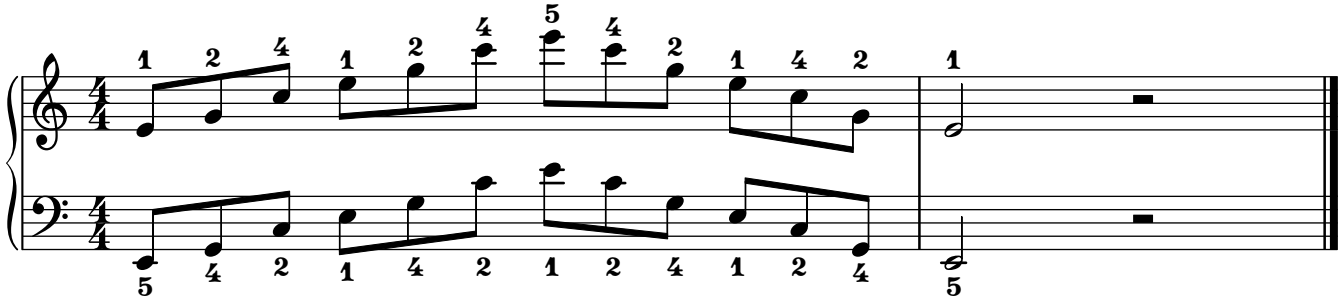


☐ **F major, contrary motion**

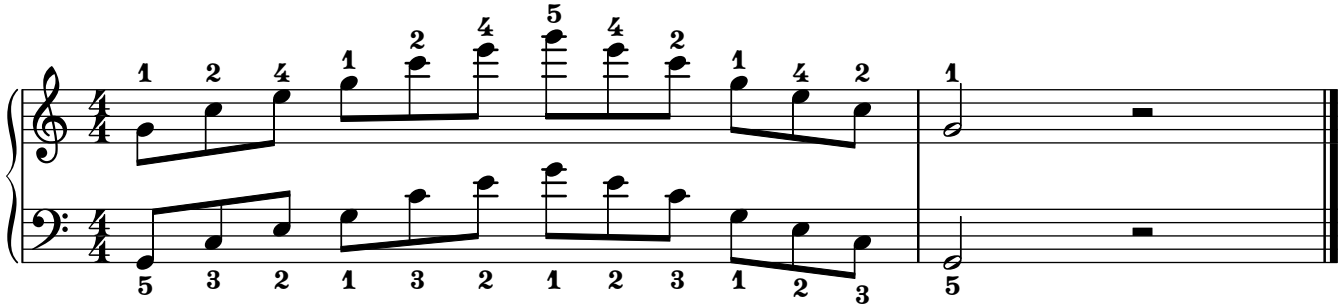


Arpeggios in inversion

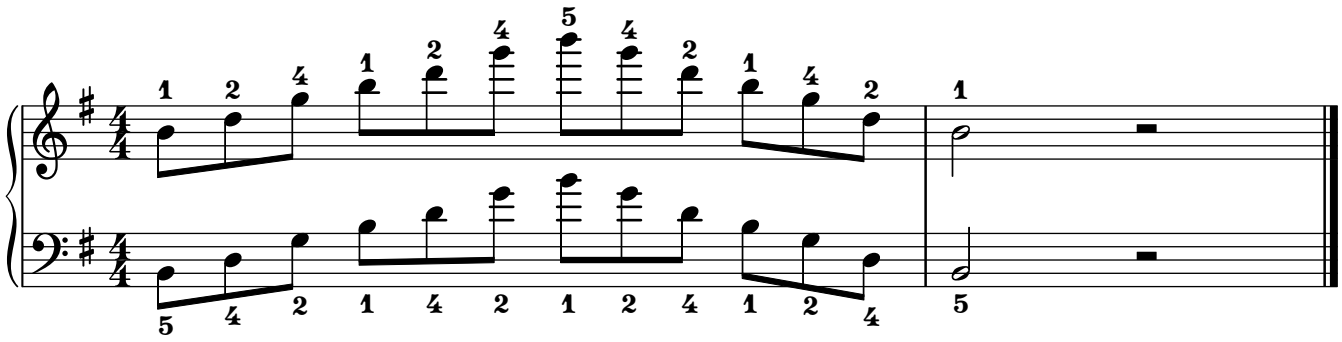
☐ **C major, first inversion**



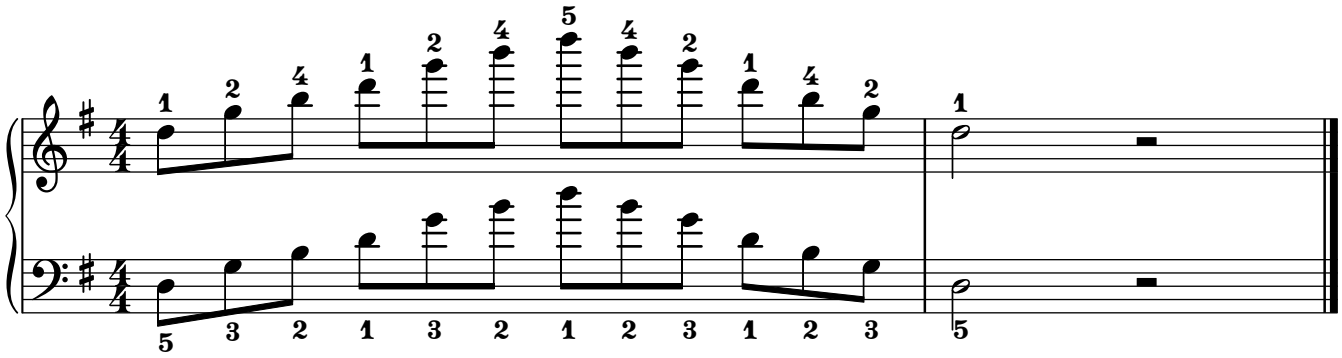
☐ **C major, second inversion**



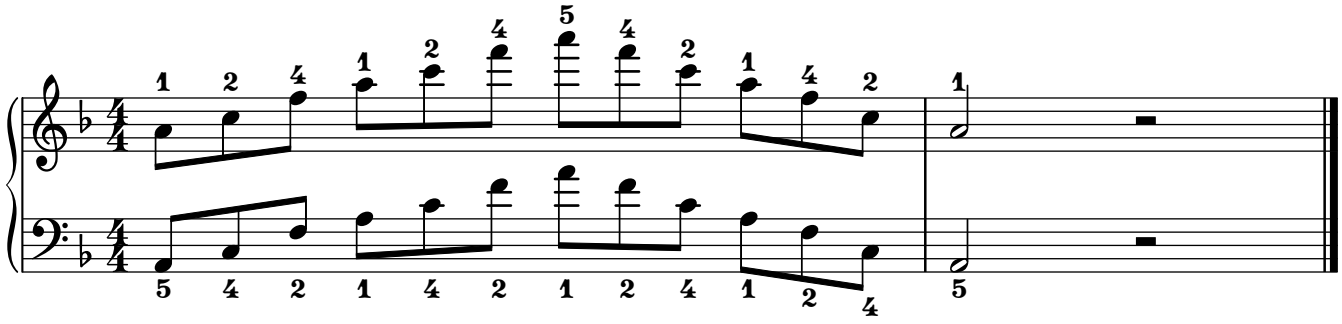
☐ **G major, first inversion**



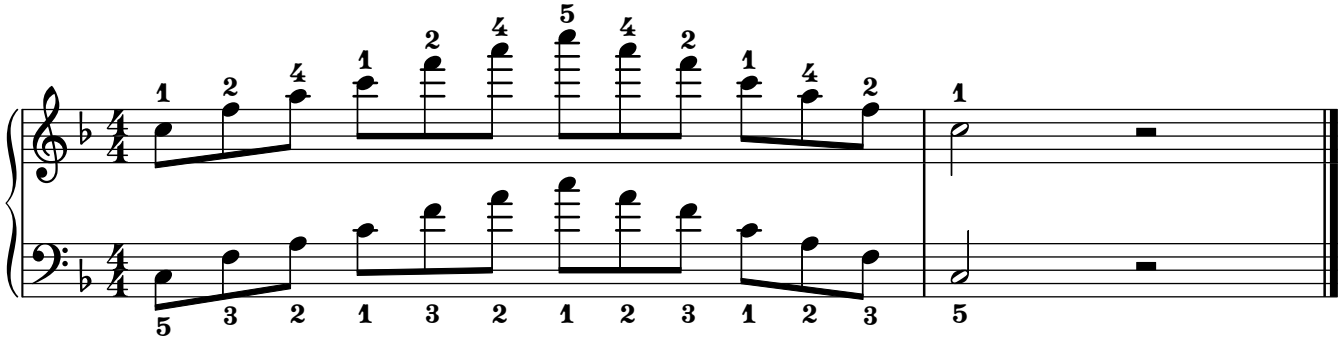
☐ **G major, second inversion**



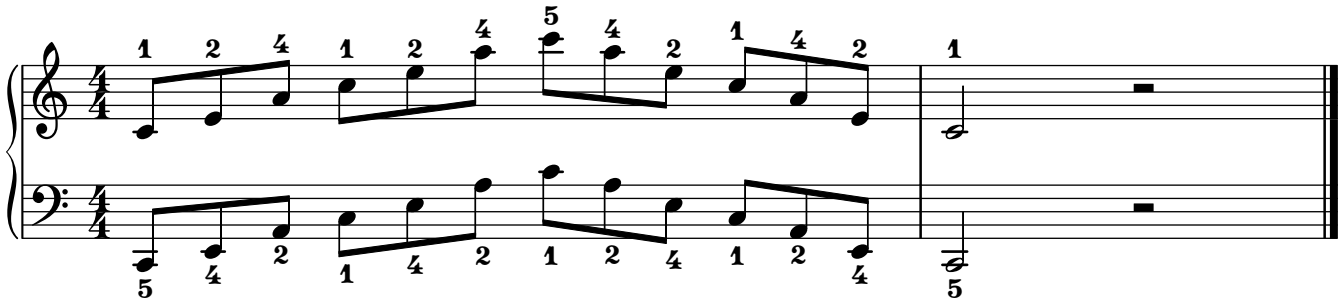
☐ **F major, first inversion**



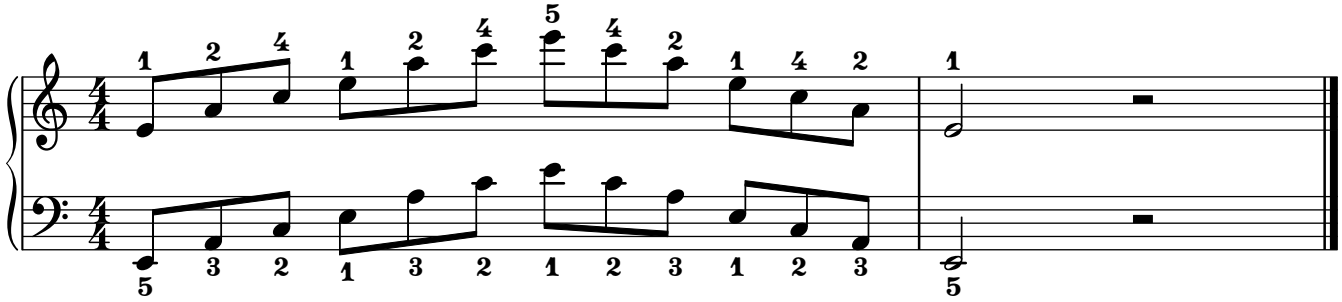
☐ **F major, second inversion**



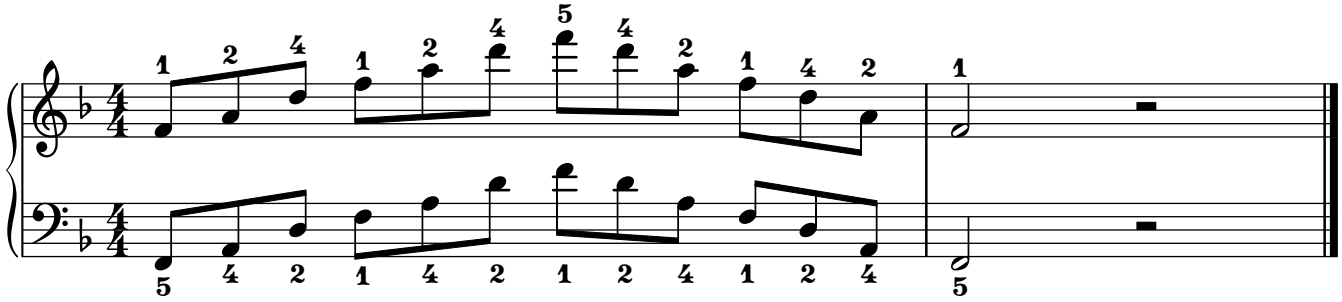
☐ **A minor, first inversion**



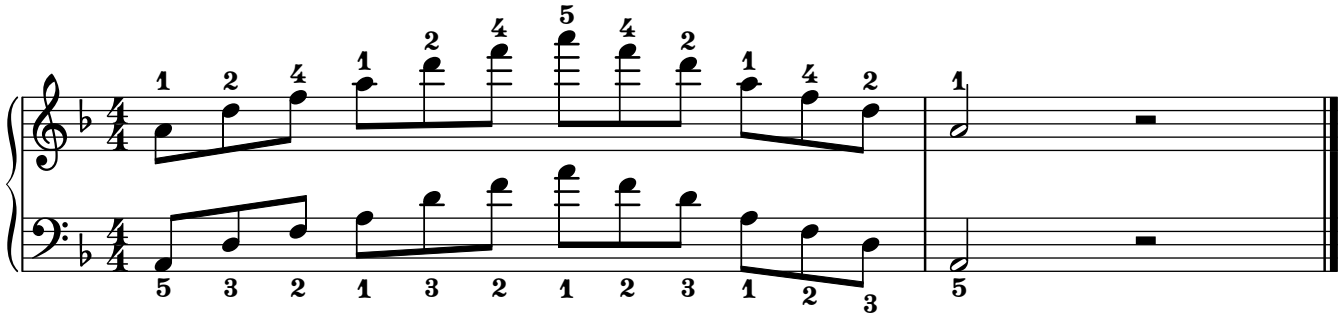
☐ **A minor, second inversion**



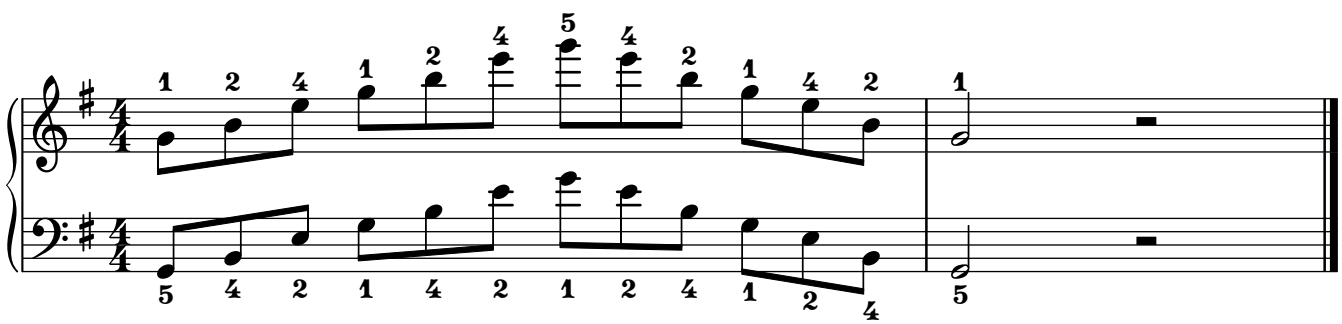
☐ **D minor, first inversion**



☐ **D minor, second inversion**



☐ **E minor, first inversion**



☐ **E minor, second inversion**

